Catechism.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 7 · DAYS 150-199

Wilderness: Numbers and Deuteronomy

Numbers, Deuteronomy

Forty years of testing, failing, and being sustained. Moses prepares Israel for the land.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one. You shall love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your might."

DEUTERONOMY 6:4-5

Psalm 90 and Psalms 95, 96, 99, and 100 beside Numbers. Psalms 78 and 119 beside Deuteronomy.

UNIT 7

In this unit

WEEK 22

150	Numbers 1:1-2:34	*Reading*
151	Numbers 3:1-4:49	*Reading*
152	Numbers 5:1-6:27	*Reading*
153	Psalm 90	*Psalm*
154	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 23

155	Numbers 7:1-89	*Reading*
156	Numbers 8:1-10:36	*Reading*
157	Numbers 11:1-12:16	*Reading*
158	Numbers 13:1-14:45	*Reading*
159	Psalm 95	*Psalm*
160	Psalm 96	*Psalm*
161	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 24

162	Numbers 15:1-16:50	*Reading*
163	Numbers 17:1-19:22	*Reading*
164	Numbers 20:1-21:35	*Reading*
165	Numbers 22:1-24:25	*Reading*
166	Psalm 99	*Psalm*
167	Psalm 100	*Psalm*
168	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 25

169	Numbers 25:1-27:23	*Reading*
170	Numbers 28:1-30:16	*Reading*
171	Numbers 31:1-32:42	*Reading*

172	Numbers 33:1-34:29	*Reading*
173	Numbers 35:1-36:13	*Reading*
174	Deuteronomy 1:1-3:29	*Reading*
175	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 26

176	Psalm 78:1-39	*Psalm*
177	Deuteronomy 4:1-5:33	*Reading*
178	Deuteronomy 6:1-8:20	*Reading*
179	Deuteronomy 9:1-11:32	*Reading*
180	Psalm 78:40-72	*Psalm*
181	Deuteronomy 12:1-14:29	*Reading*
182	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 27

183	Deuteronomy 15:1-16:22	*Reading*
184	Deuteronomy 18:15-19; Psalm 110; Hebrews 1:1-4	*Doctrine*
185	Deuteronomy 17:1-18:22	*Reading*
186	Deuteronomy 19:1-21:23	*Reading*
187	Deuteronomy 22:1-25:19	*Reading*
188	Deuteronomy 26:1-28:14	*Reading*
189	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 28

190	Psalm 119:1-48	*Psalm*
191	Psalm 119:49-96	*Psalm*
192	Deuteronomy 28:15-68	*Reading*
193	Deuteronomy 29:1-31:29	*Reading*
194	Deuteronomy 31:30-32:52	*Reading*
195	Deuteronomy 33:1-34:12	*Reading*
196	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 29

197	Psalm 119:97-144	*Psalm*
198	Psalm 119:145-176	*Psalm*
199	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 150 · WEEK 22

Numbers 1:1-2:34

The census, God's ordered people prepared for the journey

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 89 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 1:1-2:34. A new book begins, and it opens with a census and a camp plan. The text is full of numbers, so read it for the pattern and not for the arithmetic. Ask what it says about how God organizes and cares for his people.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel has been at Mount Sinai for almost a year. The covenant has been made, the tabernacle built, and the laws of Leviticus given. Now, on the first day of the second month of the second year, God tells Moses to count the fighting men and to arrange the camp. Numbers takes its English name from these censuses, though the Hebrew title is "In the wilderness." The book tells how a redeemed people travel from Sinai toward the land God promised, and how a whole generation fails to enter it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God commands Moses to number "all the congregation of the people of Israel, by clans, by fathers" houses' (1:2).
2. Each tribe has a named leader who helps with the count (1:5-16).
3. The total of men twenty years old and up, able to go to war, is 603,550 (1:46).
4. The Levites are not counted with the rest, because they are to care for the tabernacle (1:47-53).
5. The tribes camp around the tabernacle, three on each side, "each by his own banner" (2:2).
6. Judah camps on the east, the side of the entrance, and leads out first (2:3, 9).

7. The tabernacle and the Levites are at the center of the camp (2:17).
8. “Thus did the people of Israel. According to all that the LORD commanded Moses, so they camped by their standards, and so they set out” (2:34).

STEP 4

Interpretation

A census may seem a dull way to begin a book, but it says something important. God knows his people by name and by family. Each tribe has a leader. Each man is counted. In a world where slaves were nameless, Israel is a people whose members are known. The counting recalls the promise to Abraham of descendants like the stars, now visibly coming true in a host of hundreds of thousands.

The census is also a military preparation. Israel is about to march toward a land that other nations hold. The numbers are meant to give confidence, and they also bring responsibility, since each man counted is accountable to serve. But this army is not led by generals. It follows the tabernacle, and the cloud.

The camp plan is a picture in space. The tabernacle sits in the center, and twelve tribes surround it in four groups of three. God does not dwell at the edge. He is the center, and all of life is arranged around him. The Levites camp between the tabernacle and the people, a protective ring that reflects the holiness you read about in Leviticus. Everyone has a place, and no one is left out.

Notice the repeated phrase, “as the LORD commanded Moses.” The book begins with obedience. It is the high point before the failure that follows. For a moment, Israel is exactly what God designed: a people in order, near their God, ready to move. The tragedy of the rest of Numbers is that this orderly people will not trust the God who has arranged them.

For us, the lesson is simple. God does not scatter his people. He gathers them around himself and gives each a place and a task.

STEP 5

Connection

The church is described in the same terms. Paul says that God arranged the members of the body “as he chose” (1 Corinthians 12:18), and Ephesians 4:16 speaks of the whole body “joined and held together.” Hebrews 12:23 speaks of “the assembly of the firstborn who are enrolled in heaven,” and Jesus told his disciples to rejoice that their names are written in heaven (Luke 10:20). Revelation 21:12-14 pictures the twelve tribes and the twelve apostles around the new Jerusalem.

STEP 6

Application

Thank God that he knows you by name, and that you are counted among his people.

Ask where your place is in the body of Christ, and whether you are filling it.

Notice the centrality of the tabernacle in Israel's camp, and ask what is at the center of your life.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he knows his people by name and that you are counted among them.

Ask him to put you where he wants you in his body.

Ask him to keep himself at the center of your life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 22

"The LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face to shine upon you and be gracious to you; the LORD lift up his countenance upon you and give you peace."

NUMBERS 6:24-26

DAY 151 · WEEK 22

Numbers 3:1-4:49

The Levites and their duties, sacred service

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 97 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 3:1-4:49. Yesterday you saw the camp of the tribes. Today you read about the tribe of Levi, who were set apart to serve in the tabernacle. Notice the contrast between the Levites and the firstborn of Israel.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Numbers 3 and 4 describe the Levites, the tribe of Moses and Aaron. They are not counted with the army, because their work is different: they guard and carry the tabernacle. The chapters list the three clans of Levi, Gershon, Kohath, and Merari, and assign each a duty. They also explain why the Levites belong to God. When the firstborn of Egypt died at the Passover, the firstborn of Israel were spared, and so they belonged to the LORD. God takes the Levites as a substitute for them.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The sons of Aaron are named, and the death of Nadab and Abihu is recalled (3:1-4).
2. The Levites are given to Aaron “as a gift” to assist him (3:5-10).
3. “I have taken the Levites from among the people of Israel instead of every firstborn” (3:12).
4. The three clans of Levi camp on three sides of the tabernacle, with Moses and Aaron at the east (3:21-39).
5. The firstborn of Israel outnumber the Levites by 273, and each of the extra is redeemed for five shekels (3:40-51).

6. The Kohathites carry the holy things, but must not touch or look at them, “lest they die” (4:15, 20).
7. Aaron and his sons must first cover the furniture before the Kohathites come to carry it (4:5-15).
8. The Levites serve from age thirty to fifty (4:3, 23, 30).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This section teaches one of the Bible’s basic ideas: substitution. The firstborn of Israel were saved at the Passover, and they belonged to God because of it. Instead of requiring every firstborn son to serve at the sanctuary, God takes the Levites in their place. The Levites stand in for the firstborn, and when there are extra firstborn, a ransom price is paid. The principle is that a life spared must be given back to the one who spared it.

The Levites’ work is a lesson in reverence. The Kohathites carry the most holy things, but they are never allowed to touch them or look at them directly. The priests have to cover the furniture first. It is a vivid warning that God’s holiness is not casual. Even people set apart to serve him can only approach him in the way he has provided.

The text also shows the dignity of ordinary service. Much of the Levites’ work was carrying poles and curtains. It was heavy and repetitive. But Numbers describes it carefully, with each task named, because in God’s household no task is small. The people who carried the tent poles are as precisely recorded as the priests who burned the incense.

And the redemption of the extra firstborn shows how seriously God takes the ransom principle. Five shekels each is a price, a reminder that the people did not belong to themselves.

All of this prepares the reader for the greater substitution. God spared Israel’s firstborn, and then God gave his own firstborn, the only Son, as a ransom for many.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is called “the firstborn of all creation” and “the firstborn from the dead” (Colossians 1:15, 18). Believers are called “the assembly of the firstborn” (Hebrews 12:23). Peter says that you were “ransomed from the futile ways inherited from your forefathers, not with perishable things such as silver or gold, but with the precious blood of Christ” (1 Peter 1:18-19). Paul says that you are not your own, because you were bought with a price (1 Corinthians 6:19-20).

STEP 6

Application

Think about what it means to belong to God because of what he has done for you. Ask how that shapes your daily choices.

Honor those who do humble service in your church, such as people who set up, clean, or carry.

Receive the ransom with gratitude, and offer your service back to the one who redeemed you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the ransom of his Son, and tell him what it means that you are not your own.

Offer him your hands and your days, naming one thing specific.

Ask him to teach you to honor his holiness.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 22

"The LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face to shine upon you and be gracious to you; the LORD lift up his countenance upon you and give you peace."

NUMBERS 6:24-26

DAY 152 · WEEK 22

Numbers 5:1-6:27

Purity laws; the Nazirite vow; the Aaronic blessing

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 51 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 5:1-6:27. This reading includes some unusual laws about purity and suspicion, the Nazirite vow, and the best-known blessing in the Old Testament. Read the blessing at the end aloud.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The camp is arranged, and now it has to be kept clean, because God lives in it. Chapter 5 deals with people who are unclean, with wrongs that need restitution, and with a ritual for a suspected case of unfaithfulness in marriage. Chapter 6 describes the Nazirite vow, a special period of consecration that anyone could take. The chapter ends with the words Aaron and his sons were to speak over Israel.

STEP 3

Observation

1. People with skin diseases or discharges, or who have touched the dead, are sent out of the camp, “that they may not defile their camp, in the midst of which I dwell” (5:1-4).
2. A person who wrongs another must confess, make restitution, and add a fifth (5:5-10).
3. The ritual for a suspected wife is described in detail (5:11-31).
4. A Nazirite vows to abstain from wine and grape products, to let the hair grow, and to avoid contact with the dead (6:1-8).
5. If the vow is broken by accident, the Nazirite shaves and brings offerings (6:9-12).
6. At the end of the vow, offerings are made, and the hair is burned (6:13-21).
7. “The LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face to shine upon you and be gracious to you; the LORD lift up his countenance upon you and give you peace” (6:24-

26).

8 “So shall they put my name upon the people of Israel, and I will bless them” (6:27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The laws in chapter 5 continue the theme of God’s presence in the camp. Since the LORD dwells among them, anything that spoils the community’s purity is a serious matter. It is not just about private cleanliness. The people are one body, and the sin or uncleanness of one affects all.

The law about restitution is worth noting. Confession is not enough. A person who has wronged someone must pay back what was taken, plus a fifth, and the payment goes to the wronged person. True repentance has practical shape.

The suspected-adultery ritual is unusual and hard to understand today. It was designed to protect an accused woman from a husband’s jealousy by placing the matter in God’s hands. It was a way of keeping a suspicion from turning into violence, and it put the verdict in the hands of the God who sees all things.

The Nazirite vow is a different kind of consecration. Priests were born to their roles, but a Nazirite chose his. Any man or woman could set themselves apart for a time. The three signs of the vow, no grapes, uncut hair, and no contact with the dead, marked a life given wholly to God. It reminds us that holiness is available to everyone.

The blessing at the end is a gem. It has three lines, each longer than the one before, and each is a prayer for God’s favor: his protection, his face turned toward us, and his peace. The key phrase is “put my name upon the people.” The blessing is not Aaron’s. It is the LORD’s. The people are marked with his name, and the blessing is his gift to them.

STEP 5

Connection

Samson, Samuel, and John the Baptist were set apart as Nazirites or in a similar way. Paul took a vow of this kind (Acts 18:18). Jesus is the greater one who was wholly consecrated to the Father. Paul prays a version of the blessing in his letters (2 Corinthians 13:14; Philippians 4:7). Hebrews 7:1 says that Melchizedek blessed Abraham, and Jesus lifted his hands and blessed his disciples as he ascended (Luke 24:50-51).

STEP 6

Application

Read the blessing aloud, and receive it as a word spoken over you personally. Then speak it over someone you love.

Think about whether there is something you need to confess and repay.

Consider what it would mean to set aside something for a season so that you could give more to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Pray the Aaronic blessing over yourself, slowly, in your own words.
- Ask him to put his name on you and make you a blessing.
- Pray the same blessing over someone you love.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 22

"The LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face to shine upon you and be gracious to you; the LORD lift up his countenance upon you and give you peace."

NUMBERS 6:24-26

DAY 153 · WEEK 22

Psalm 90

Moses' psalm, God's eternity against human frailty

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Psalm · 17 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 90. It is the only psalm attributed to Moses. Read it as a reflection by a man who has led a rebellious people for forty years and knows both God's eternity and human weakness.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 90 opens the fourth book of the Psalms. The title is "A Prayer of Moses, the man of God." If Moses wrote it, it comes from the wilderness years, when a whole generation died without entering the promised land. The sense of time passing, of lives cut short, and of God's anger against sin runs through it. It is placed here as a companion to the book of Numbers.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Lord, you have been our dwelling place in all generations" (v. 1).
2. "Before the mountains were brought forth, or ever you had formed the earth and the world, from everlasting to everlasting you are God" (v. 2).
3. "You return man to dust and say, Return, O children of man!" (v. 3).
4. "For a thousand years in your sight are but as yesterday when it is past, or as a watch in the night" (v. 4).
5. "The years of our life are seventy, or even by reason of strength eighty" (v. 10).
6. "So teach us to number our days that we may get a heart of wisdom" (v. 12).
7. "Satisfy us in the morning with your steadfast love, that we may rejoice and be glad all our days" (v. 14).

8 “Let the favor of the Lord our God be upon us, and establish the work of our hands upon us; yes, establish the work of our hands!” (v. 17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a surprising claim for a people with no home: “You have been our dwelling place.” Israel had no land and lived in tents. But Moses says that their true home was never a place. It was God. This is the first sentence of the psalm, and everything else depends on it.

Then comes a contrast between God’s eternity and human frailty. God is from everlasting to everlasting. We are like grass that sprouts in the morning and withers by evening. Moses does not say this to make us feel hopeless. He says it so that we see how much we depend on God.

The cause of our frailty is not only that we are creatures. It is that we are sinners. Verses 7 to 11 connect human mortality to God’s anger. “We are brought to an end by your anger.” Moses had watched a generation die in the wilderness because of unbelief, and he knows that death is not natural. It is a sign of judgment. Our secret sins are “in the light of your presence.”

But the psalm does not end with despair. It turns in verse 12, with a prayer: “Teach us to number our days.” The right response to our short lives is wisdom, living each day with an awareness of its limits. Then it asks for compassion: “Have pity on your servants.” It asks for joy in the morning, joy to match the years of affliction. And it ends with a request that the work of our hands might be established. God’s favor is what makes small and brief work last.

It is a good psalm to read at the start of a long book about the wilderness. It reminds us that the journey is brief, that God is our home, and that his steadfast love is the only thing that satisfies.

STEP 5

Connection

Peter quotes verse 4 when he says that “with the Lord one day is as a thousand years” (2 Peter 3:8). James says that life is “a mist that appears for a little time and then vanishes” (James 4:14). Paul teaches that death entered through sin and that Christ has defeated it (Romans 5:12; 1 Corinthians 15:54-57). Jesus said that in his Father’s house there are many rooms (John 14:2), and he is our dwelling place now.

STEP 6

Application

Ask yourself how many days you may have left, and what you most want to do with them. Pray verse 12 for yourself.

Think about the work you are doing right now. Ask God to establish it, and to make it last for his purposes.

Thank God that he is your dwelling place, even when you feel like a wanderer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for being your dwelling place in every season of life.
- Ask him to teach you to number your days and gain a heart of wisdom.
- Ask him to establish the work of your hands for his glory.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 22

"The LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face to shine upon you and be gracious to you; the LORD lift up his countenance upon you and give you peace."

NUMBERS 6:24-26

DAY 154 · WEEK 22

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Numbers 6:24-26 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face to shine upon you and be gracious to you; the LORD lift up his countenance upon you and give you peace."

NUMBERS 6:24-26

REST

Meditation

The Aaronic blessing is one of the oldest pieces of Scripture still used in worship. It has been said over God's people for three thousand years. Receive it as if it is spoken to you today.

"The LORD bless you and keep you." The blessing begins with God's goodness and protection. To keep means to guard and watch over, as a shepherd keeps his flock. It does not promise a life without trouble. It promises the one who keeps us in trouble.

"The LORD make his face to shine upon you and be gracious to you." The face of God shining is a picture of his favor and delight. A father's smile gives a child confidence. God's face, turned toward you in grace, is the deepest blessing there is.

“The LORD lift up his countenance upon you and give you peace.” The picture is of God looking at you, lifting his face, and giving shalom. Peace here is not only calm. It means wholeness, the well-being of every part of life.

Notice that the name of the LORD stands at the start of each line. He is the one who blesses, and he does it by putting his name on his people. For Christians, this is fulfilled in Christ. In him, God’s face has shone on us (2 Corinthians 4:6), and he has made peace through the blood of his cross (Colossians 1:20).

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the book of Numbers. You read about the census of Israel and the arrangement of the camp around the tabernacle, and you saw that God knows his people by name. You read about the Levites, who were given to God in place of the firstborn, and who carried the tabernacle with reverence. You read laws of purity and restitution, the Nazirite vow, and the blessing that God commanded Aaron to speak over his people. In Psalm 90, you heard Moses pray about the brevity of life and the eternity of God. The week taught that God orders and protects his people, that he claims them by substitution, and that he blesses them with his own name.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The camp was arranged around the tabernacle. What is at the center of your life, and how would your daily schedule change if God’s presence were at the center?

The Levites were taken in place of the firstborn. How does the idea of substitution deepen your understanding of what Christ did for you?

Psalm 90 asks, “Teach us to number our days.” What is one thing you would do differently if you took the shortness of life seriously?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for blessing and keeping you this week, naming one way.

Thank him for putting his name on his people.

Rest in his presence today.

DAY 155 · WEEK 23

Numbers 7:1-89

The offerings of the leaders, devotion in detail

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 89 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 7:1-89. This is the longest chapter in the book, and it records the same offering twelve times. Read it with patience, and ask why the Holy Spirit would give so much space to repetition.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The tabernacle has been set up and anointed. Now the twelve tribal leaders bring gifts for its dedication: carts and oxen for the Levites, and then, one leader per day for twelve days, an identical offering of silver and gold vessels, animals, and grain. It is the last event in the book before the departure from Sinai, and it is the longest chapter of Numbers. It ends with a short note about Moses hearing the voice of God from the mercy seat.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The leaders bring six covered wagons and twelve oxen as an offering (7:1-3).
2. God tells Moses to give the wagons to the Levites, according to their needs (7:4-9).
3. Each leader brings an offering on his own day: “Nahshon the son of Amminadab of the tribe of Judah” first (7:12).
4. Each offering is the same: a silver plate, a silver basin, a golden dish of incense, animals for burnt, sin, and peace offerings (7:13-17).
5. The text repeats the list for each of the twelve tribes (7:18-83).
6. The total is added up at the end (7:84-88).
7. The Kohathites receive no wagons, because their duty is to carry the holy things on their shoulders (7:9).

8 “And when Moses went into the tent of meeting to speak with the LORD, he heard the voice speaking to him from above the mercy seat that was on the ark of the testimony” (7:89).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The repetition in this chapter is the point. Each tribe brings exactly the same gift, even though some were large and some small, and some were wealthy and some poor. No one tries to outdo the others. No one is left out. The identical gifts say that every tribe has an equal share in the worship of God. Judah, the leading tribe, and Naphtali, one of the smallest, are written down with the same lines.

The chapter also shows that God notices every gift. Twelve times the same words are written out in full. A modern editor would have said “the other tribes did likewise.” But God gives each leader his own paragraph, because each gift is individually received and individually remembered. Nothing given to God is lost in a crowd.

The detail about the wagons is easy to miss. The leaders give the Levites what they need to do their work. The Levites in the families of Gershon and Merari get wagons and oxen, in proportion to their burden. The Kohathites, whose task is the holiest, get none, because the holy things must be carried on the shoulder. The offerings of the people serve the needs of the ministry, and every task has its own tools.

The chapter ends quietly with a verse that is easy to pass over: Moses enters the tent of meeting and hears the voice of God. This is the answer to the whole purpose of the tabernacle. All the gifts, the carts, the silver, and the animals lead to a place where God speaks to his servant. The worship and generosity of the people make room for God’s voice.

It may feel strange to read the same list twelve times. But treat it as a reminder that no act of devotion is trivial to God.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus praised the widow who gave two small coins, because she gave more than the rich (Mark 12:41-44). Paul wrote that “each of you should give what you have decided in your heart to give” (2 Corinthians 9:7), and that the church is a body in which every member matters (1 Corinthians 12). Hebrews 4:16 says that we can approach “the throne of grace” with confidence. Jesus speaks to us from heaven by his word.

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on whether you compare your giving to others. Ask God to make you content to give what he has put in your hand.

Remember that God notices what you do in secret. Offer something to him today that no one else will see.

Ask the Lord to speak to you through his Word, as he did to Moses.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to help you give without comparing yourself to others.

Thank him that he remembers each gift.

Thank him that he speaks to you through his Word.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 23

"Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts, as at Meribah, as on the day at Massah in the wilderness."

PSALM 95:7-8

DAY 156 · WEEK 23

Numbers 8:1-10:36

The Levites consecrated; the cloud; the silver trumpets

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 85 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 8:1-10:36. This reading covers the lampstand, the consecration of the Levites, a second Passover, and the departure from Sinai. Notice the role of the cloud and the trumpets in guiding the people.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the end of Israel's year at Sinai. In these chapters, God completes the preparations for the march. The lamps are lit, the Levites are set apart for service, and a second Passover is kept, with a provision for those who were unclean. The cloud and the silver trumpets give the signals to move. Then, on the twentieth day of the second month of the second year, the cloud lifts from the tabernacle and Israel leaves Sinai.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Aaron sets up the lamps to give light "in front of the lampstand" (8:1-4).
2. The Levites are cleansed with water, shaved, and presented, and the people lay their hands on them (8:5-13).
3. The Levites are "wholly given to me from among the people of Israel" (8:16).
4. The Passover is observed in the second year, and a second chance is given to those who were unclean or traveling (9:1-14).
5. The cloud covers the tabernacle by day and has the appearance of fire by night (9:15-16).
6. "At the command of the LORD they camped, and at the command of the LORD they set out" (9:23).
7. Two silver trumpets are made to call the congregation and to signal the march (10:1-10).

8 The ark leads the way, and Moses says, “Rise up, O LORD, and let your enemies be scattered” and “Return, O LORD, to the ten thousands of thousands of Israel” (10:33-36).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Levites’ consecration echoes the laying on of hands in the sacrifices. The people lay their hands on the Levites, as if to say, “These stand for us.” Then the Levites lay their hands on the bulls for the sin offering and burnt offering. The pattern is a chain of substitution: the people give the Levites, and the Levites give the animals. It shows how the gift of a servant leads back to the sacrifice that makes service possible.

The second Passover is a small, kind detail. Some men were unclean and could not keep the first Passover, and they ask Moses what to do. God answers by creating a make-up date, a second Passover a month later. The law shows a flexible grace. God does not want anyone to be left out of the meal because of circumstances they could not help.

The cloud is the centerpiece of this section. Israel does not set its own schedule. When the cloud lifts, they move, and when it stays, they stay, whether for two days, a month, or a year. The text says it three times, so we cannot miss it. It is hard to be led like this. It requires trust, patience, and a readiness to leave a comfortable place. But the people are guided by the presence of God himself.

The silver trumpets add voice to this guidance. They call the people together and signal war and feasts. Even the sound of the camp is arranged by God. And Moses’ words at the ark are a prayer: “Rise up, O LORD.” It is a battle prayer, but it is also a statement of faith. The LORD goes before his people, and they follow.

You are looking at the high point of Israel’s obedience. They have left Sinai in order, with the ark in front and the cloud above. The next chapter will show how quickly it goes wrong.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus told his disciples, “Follow me” (Matthew 4:19), and he said that his sheep “hear my voice, and I know them, and they follow me” (John 10:27). Paul writes that “all who are led by the Spirit of God are sons of God” (Romans 8:14). The ascension of Christ was accompanied by a cloud (Acts 1:9), and the Lord will return “with a cry of command, with the voice of an archangel, and with the sound of the trumpet of God” (1 Thessalonians 4:16).

STEP 6

Application

Think about a place where you are waiting for God to move. Ask him to give you patience and trust.

If you are in a season of change, pray that God would show you whether to stay or go.

Pray Moses' words from 10:35-36 as a prayer for your church and your family.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to lead you by his Spirit and Word.
- Tell him where you need patience to wait or courage to move.
- Pray "Rise up, O LORD" over the road ahead.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 23

"Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts, as at Meribah, as on the day at Massah in the wilderness."

PSALM 95:7-8

DAY 157 · WEEK 23

Numbers 11:1-12:16

Complaining; quail and plague; Miriam's leprosy

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 51 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 11:1-12:16. The march begins, and within days the people are complaining. Read these two chapters as a portrait of grumbling, and notice who says it, and what God does in response.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel has left Sinai with the ark in front and the cloud above. Three days later, the complaining starts. Chapter 11 describes three crises: general grumbling that leads to fire, a craving for meat that leads to quail and a plague, and Moses' own exhaustion. Chapter 12 describes an attack on Moses from within his own family. The chapters show that the greatest danger to Israel is not Egypt behind them or Canaan ahead, but the hearts of the people themselves.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And the people complained in the hearing of the LORD about their misfortunes, and when the LORD heard it, his anger was kindled" (11:1).
2. Fire from the LORD burns at the edge of the camp, until Moses prays and it dies down (11:1-3).
3. The "rabble" among them crave meat, and the Israelites say, "Oh that we had meat to eat! We remember the fish we ate in Egypt that cost nothing" (11:4-5).
4. Moses says to God, "Why have you dealt ill with your servant?... I am not able to carry all this people alone" (11:11-14).
5. God has Moses gather seventy elders, and he puts some of the Spirit that was on Moses on them, and they prophesy (11:16-25).

6. Eldad and Medad prophesy in the camp, and Moses says, “Would that all the LORD’s people were prophets” (11:26-29).
7. Quail come in, and the people gorge, and a plague breaks out (11:31-35).
8. Miriam and Aaron speak against Moses. “Now the man Moses was very meek, more than all people who were on the face of the earth” (12:1-3). Miriam becomes leprous, and Moses prays for her (12:10-15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The pattern of Israel’s grumbling is a mirror for our own hearts. The people forget the slavery and remember only the food. They say that Egypt’s fish was free. It was not. It cost them their freedom. This is one of the most common human mistakes: remembering the pleasures of an old life and forgetting its chains. Nostalgia is a form of unbelief.

The craving for meat is not wrong because meat is wrong. It is wrong because the people had the manna, God’s daily provision, and called it worthless. They were despising the gift, and they were despising the giver. When God gives them what they want, in excess, it becomes a judgment. “He gave them what they asked, but sent a wasting disease among them,” as Psalm 106:15 says. Sometimes the worst thing God can do is give us what we demand.

Moses’ own complaint is notable. He is not rebuked as the people are, but his prayer shows how heavy leadership is. God’s answer is to share the load: he puts the Spirit on seventy elders. The burden is not removed. It is shared. And Moses’ response to Eldad and Medad is one of the great statements of the Old Testament: “Would that all the LORD’s people were prophets, that the LORD would put his Spirit on them!” It is a prayer that waits for the new covenant.

Chapter 12 shows how even those closest to Moses can fall. Miriam and Aaron criticize Moses’ wife and claim that they should share his authority. The text says that Moses was very meek, and he does not defend himself. God defends him. God speaks to Moses “face to face,” unlike other prophets, and Miriam is struck. The chapter shows how seriously God takes the authority of the one he appoints. And Moses prays for her healing, a beautiful example of a meek man who returns good for evil.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that these things “took place as examples for us, that we might not desire evil as they did” (1 Corinthians 10:6, 10), and he specifically warns against grumbling. Peter echoes Moses’ wish at Pentecost, when the Spirit is poured out on all flesh (Acts 2:17-18). Hebrews

3:1-6 compares Moses' faithfulness "as a servant" with Christ's faithfulness "as a son." Jesus is the meek one who prayed for those who wronged him (Luke 23:34).

STEP 6

Application

Notice your own grumbling this week. What are you remembering from the past that you have forgotten the cost of?

Thank God for a specific gift that you have taken for granted, the manna in your own life.

Pray for a leader you know, and ask God to share the burden of leadership with others.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you have grumbled about what God has given.
- Ask him to teach you gratitude for your daily bread.
- Thank him for Jesus, who gives the Spirit to all his people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 23

"Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts, as at Meribah, as on the day at Massah in the wilderness."

PSALM 95:7-8

DAY 158 · WEEK 23

Numbers 13:1-14:45

The twelve spies; the faithless report; forty years

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 65 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 13:1-14:45. This is the turning point of the book and one of the saddest chapters in the Old Testament. Read it as the story of a failure of faith, and note carefully what the people say, and what God says in reply.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel has come to the edge of Canaan, at Kadesh in the wilderness of Paran. God tells Moses to send twelve men, one from each tribe, to explore the land. They go for forty days and return with a report. Ten say the land is good but its people are too strong. Two, Joshua and Caleb, say that God will give it to them. The people believe the ten. What follows is the decisive failure of the exodus generation.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God says, “Send men to spy out the land of Canaan, which I am giving to the people of Israel” (13:2).
2. The spies bring back a cluster of grapes so large that it is carried on a pole by two men (13:23).
3. All twelve agree: “It flows with milk and honey” (13:27).
4. Ten report: “We are not able to go up against the people, for they are stronger than we… we seemed to ourselves like grasshoppers” (13:31-33).
5. Caleb says, “Let us go up at once and occupy it, for we are well able to overcome it” (13:30).

6. The people weep and say, “Would that we had died in the land of Egypt!” and propose to choose a leader and go back (14:1-4).

7. Moses pleads for the people, appealing to God’s name: “The LORD is slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love” (14:13-19).

8. God pardons them, but says that none of the men who saw his signs and yet tested him ten times shall see the land. Their children will enter, after forty years of wandering (14:20-35).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The sin here is not caution. It is unbelief. God had already said that he was giving them the land. The spies were not sent to decide whether to go, but to see what God was giving. When ten of them look at the land and then look at themselves, they forget God. Their report shifts from “the land flows with milk and honey” to “the land devours its inhabitants.” And their self-image shrinks: “we seemed to ourselves like grasshoppers.” Fear distorts how we see ourselves and how we see God.

Joshua and Caleb saw the same land and the same giants. The difference was not in what they saw, but in what they believed about God. Caleb says, “we are well able,” and Joshua says, “the LORD is with us; do not fear them.” Faith does not deny the giants. It remembers who is bigger.

The people’s reaction is a tragedy. They weep all night. They say they wish they had died in Egypt, and they even say that God brought them out because he hates them (Deuteronomy 1:27). They call good evil. In a few hours, they undo the whole exodus in their minds.

Moses’ intercession is a high point. He does not argue that Israel deserves mercy. He argues from God’s own character, quoting the words of Exodus 34:6-7. And God does pardon the people, but he does not remove the consequences. The generation that refused to enter will not enter. Forgiveness and discipline are both real.

The last scene shows how unbelief hardens into presumption. When told they will not enter, the people suddenly decide to attack on their own. Without God, they are defeated. Obedience delayed is not the same as obedience. They had refused to go when God said go, and now they went when God said no.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 3 and 4 use this story as a warning to the church. “Take care, brothers, lest there be in any of you an evil, unbelieving heart, leading you to fall away from the living God” (Hebrews 3:12). The generation “were unable to enter because of unbelief” (Hebrews 3:19). The promise of rest still stands, and Jesus, whose name is the same as Joshua’s, leads us in. Paul says that these events were written down for our instruction (1 Corinthians 10:11).

STEP 6

Application

Ask what giant you are facing, and whether you are seeing it through your own eyes or God’s promise.

Is there something God has told you to do that you are delaying? Obey today, not later.

Pray for the courage of Joshua and Caleb, to speak the truth even when the crowd is afraid.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God where you have been looking at giants instead of promises.
- Confess your unbelief and ask for a spirit like Caleb’s.
- Thank Jesus for leading his people into rest.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 23

“Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts, as at Meribah, as on the day at Massah in the wilderness.”

PSALM 95:7-8

DAY 159 · WEEK 23

Psalm 95

Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 95. Yesterday's chapter described a generation that hardened its heart. Today's psalm reads that story as a warning to us. Read it aloud, and notice the sudden change of tone in verse 7.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 95 is a psalm of worship that has been sung in the church's morning prayer for centuries. It starts with a joyful call to come and sing, and then shifts at the end into an urgent warning drawn from Numbers 14. The psalm does not name its author, but Hebrews 4:7 attributes it to David. The setting is the worship of the gathered congregation, who are reminded that praise must go with obedience.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh come, let us sing to the LORD; let us make a joyful noise to the rock of our salvation!" (v. 1).
2. "Let us come into his presence with thanksgiving; let us make a joyful noise to him with songs of praise!" (v. 2).
3. "For the LORD is a great God, and a great King above all gods" (v. 3).
4. "In his hand are the depths of the earth; the heights of the mountains are his also" (v. 4).
5. "Oh come, let us worship and bow down; let us kneel before the LORD, our Maker!" (v. 6).
6. "For he is our God, and we are the people of his pasture, and the sheep of his hand" (v. 7).

7. “Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts, as at Meribah, as on the day at Massah in the wilderness” (vv. 7-8).

8. “Therefore I swore in my wrath, They shall not enter my rest” (v. 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm has two halves, and the contrast is meant to startle us. The first half, verses 1 to 7a, is full of praise: singing, shouting, thanksgiving, bowing down. The second half is a warning. The same God who is a great king and a good shepherd is also the God who swore that a generation would not enter his rest. The psalmist places the two side by side because true worship includes both.

Worship, in this psalm, has an inward and an outward side. It is noisy and joyful, and it is also quiet and obedient. “Let us kneel before the LORD” and “if you hear his voice.” It is not enough to sing loudly. The test of worship is whether we listen.

The word “today” is the key. It is a present-tense word. “Today, if you hear his voice” does not refer to the past or the future. The wilderness generation heard his voice at Sinai and then refused. The psalmist says that the same opportunity is offered to every generation. It is as urgent now as then.

The phrase “do not harden your hearts” implies that hearts can be hardened or softened by our own choices. It is a process, not an event. Each time we ignore God’s voice, it becomes easier to ignore the next time. Each time we obey, our hearts become more sensitive. We are always moving in one direction or the other.

And “my rest” is the goal of the whole journey. The land was a picture of that rest, but the real thing is deeper: to be at home with God. The sad truth is that people can sing about it, and still miss it.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 3:7-4:13 is an extended meditation on this psalm. The writer applies it to Christians: “Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts.” He says that a Sabbath rest remains for the people of God, and “let us therefore strive to enter that rest” (Hebrews 4:9-11). Jesus invites, “Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest” (Matthew 11:28).

STEP 6

Application

Read Psalm 95 aloud as an act of worship. Include the warning.

Ask whether there is a place where you have been ignoring God's voice. Today is the day to listen.

Thank God that the rest he promises is found in Christ, and ask him to soften any hardness in your heart.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you want to hear his voice today.
- Ask him to keep your heart soft and keep you from unbelief.
- Thank him for the rest that is yours in Jesus.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 23

"Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts, as at Meribah, as on the day at Massah in the wilderness."

PSALM 95:7-8

DAY 160 · WEEK 23

Psalm 96

Sing to the LORD a new song

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 96. Where yesterday's psalm warned, today's celebrates. Read it as a missionary song, and notice how many times it speaks of "all the earth," "the nations," and "the peoples."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 96 is closely related to a song of David recorded in 1 Chronicles 16, sung when the ark was brought to Jerusalem. It begins with the call to "sing to the LORD a new song," and it widens quickly to include the whole world. In the context of Numbers, with its story of a people who failed in unbelief, the psalm lifts the eyes toward a future in which every nation praises the LORD.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh sing to the LORD a new song; sing to the LORD, all the earth!" (v. 1).
2. "Sing to the LORD, bless his name; tell of his salvation from day to day" (v. 2).
3. "Declare his glory among the nations, his marvelous works among all the peoples!" (v. 3).
4. "For great is the LORD, and greatly to be praised; he is to be feared above all gods" (v. 4).
5. "For all the gods of the peoples are worthless idols, but the LORD made the heavens" (v. 5).
6. "Ascribe to the LORD, O families of the peoples, ascribe to the LORD glory and strength!" (v. 7).
7. "Worship the LORD in the splendor of holiness; tremble before him, all the earth!" (v. 9).

8. “Say among the nations, The LORD reigns!... He will judge the peoples with equity” (vv. 10-13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This psalm is a call to worship that is also a call to mission. The singing is not meant to stay in Israel. It is to be declared “among the nations.” The salvation of the LORD is to be told “from day to day.” The God of Israel is not a tribal god. He made the heavens, and he is the only true God.

The “new song” is the response to a new act of salvation. Each generation has to sing for itself what God has done. It is not enough to repeat the old songs only as history. We need to make them new by remembering and applying them to our own situation.

The contrast between the LORD and the gods of the peoples is sharp. Verse 5 uses a Hebrew pun: the word for “idols” sounds like the word for “nothings.” The gods of the nations are worthless things, and the LORD made the heavens. This is the same contrast Israel had just ignored in the wilderness. The psalm urges the nations to turn from nothing to everything.

The psalm ends with creation joining in. The heavens, the earth, the sea, the fields, and the trees of the forest all rejoice, because the LORD is coming to judge the earth. The coming of God is good news for the world. He will judge with equity and truth. In a world full of injustice, this is a hope worth singing about.

After reading about Israel’s complaining, the psalm is a rebuke and an invitation. Israel’s calling was to sing, to witness, and to bring the nations in. The failure of the wilderness is not the end of the story. God will still be praised in all the earth.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus sent his disciples to “make disciples of all nations” (Matthew 28:19). Revelation 5:9 and 7:9 show a multitude from every nation praising the Lamb, singing a “new song.” Paul says that creation “will be set free from its bondage to corruption” (Romans 8:21). The coming of the Lord to judge the earth is the Christian’s hope (Acts 17:31; Revelation 19).

STEP 6

Application

Sing or read this psalm aloud. Ask God to give you a new song for something he has done recently.

Pray for a missionary or a nation that has not heard the gospel.

Tell someone this week about something God has done for you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Sing or speak to the LORD a new song, in your own words.
- Ask him to make you bold to tell of his salvation.
- Pray “Come, Lord Jesus” to judge the earth in righteousness.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 23

“Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts, as at Meribah, as on the day at Massah in the wilderness.”

PSALM 95:7-8

DAY 161 · WEEK 23

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 95:7-8 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts, as at Meribah, as on the day at Massah in the wilderness."

PSALM 95:7-8

REST

Meditation

This verse is a warning and an invitation in one breath. It was written to people who had a long history of hearing God's voice and refusing it, and it is quoted three times in the book of Hebrews to address Christians.

"Today." The word is the center of the verse. God does not speak only to those who lived long ago. He speaks today. There is a sense of urgency in the word, and also of mercy. As long as it is called "today," there is still time to respond.

"If you hear his voice." Hearing is more than sound. It is the attention that leads to obedience. Israel heard God's voice at Sinai, and they trembled, and still they refused at Kadesh. The question is not whether God speaks. It is whether we will listen.

“Do not harden your hearts.” The picture is of something soft being made hard, as clay left in the sun. It is a gradual process, and it happens through small refusals. Each time we say no to what we know God is asking, the next no comes easier.

“As at Meribah, as on the day at Massah.” Meribah means “quarreling” and Massah means “testing.” These places became names for Israel’s failure. The warning is that we can give our own lives names like these if we are not careful.

For the Christian, the verse is a call to stay close to Christ. “Exhort one another every day, as long as it is called ‘today,’ that none of you may be hardened by the deceitfulness of sin” (Hebrews 3:13).

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you followed Israel’s departure from Sinai. You read about the offerings of the tribal leaders, the consecration of the Levites, the second Passover, and the cloud that led the people by day and night. You watched the march begin with order and then break down in complaining, as the people longed for the food of Egypt and Miriam and Aaron challenged Moses. You read the story of the twelve spies, the unbelief of the people, and the judgment that a whole generation would die in the wilderness. In the Psalms, you read the warning of Psalm 95 and the missionary song of Psalm 96. The week taught that unbelief is the root of rebellion, that God’s patience is real but not endless, and that the answer is to listen today.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The ten spies saw the same land as Joshua and Caleb. What shaped the difference between their reports, and what shapes how you see your own challenges?

Hebrews says that Christ is the one who leads his people into God’s rest. How does Jesus succeed where Joshua and Moses could not?

Where might you be hardening your heart today? Write down one thing God has asked of you and what it would look like to obey today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God you want to hear his voice today, and ask him to soften any hard place in you.

Ask him for the faith of Caleb and Joshua.

Thank Jesus for leading you into his rest.

DAY 162 · WEEK 24

Numbers 15:1-16:50

Offerings; Korah's rebellion against God's appointed

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 90 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 15:1-16:50. Chapter 15 gives laws that look ahead to the land. Chapter 16 tells the story of Korah's rebellion. Read the first chapter as a reassurance, and the second as a warning.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the disaster at Kadesh, the story slows. Chapter 15 is a surprising pause: God gives laws for offerings "when you come into the land," which is a promise that his plan has not been cancelled. Chapter 16 then shows a new challenge to Moses and Aaron, led by Korah, a Levite, with Dathan and Abiram of Reuben, and 250 leaders. They object that Moses and Aaron have taken too much to themselves.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "When you come into the land you are to inhabit, which I am giving you" (15:2) introduces laws about offerings.
2. The same law applies to the native and to the sojourner (15:14-16).
3. Unintentional sins can be forgiven with a sacrifice, but "the person who does anything with a high hand… reviles the LORD" (15:22-31).
4. A man is put to death for gathering sticks on the Sabbath (15:32-36).
5. The people are told to put tassels on their garments, "that you may remember all the commandments of the LORD" (15:37-41).
6. Korah says, "You have gone too far! For all in the congregation are holy, every one of them" (16:3).

7. Moses says that the LORD will show who is his, and the ground opens and swallows Korah's household (16:28-33).

8. The next day, the people grumble again and a plague strikes. Aaron stands with the censer "between the dead and the living," and the plague stops (16:41-50).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 15 is a quiet promise in the midst of judgment. Just after God says that a generation will die in the wilderness, he gives laws that begin "when you come into the land." The children will enter. God's purposes are not defeated by the unbelief of the parents. It is a lesson to hold on to when we fail: God's plan outlasts our failures.

The distinction between unintentional sin and the sin "with a high hand" is important. A person who sins in ignorance can find forgiveness through a sacrifice. But someone who knowingly defies God is despising his word. The story of the Sabbath-breaker, who deliberately and openly broke the commandment, illustrates it. The tassels on the garments are a counterweight: a simple, visible reminder to obey. God knows we forget, and he gives us ways to remember.

Korah's rebellion is a different kind of sin. His claim sounds democratic: "All the congregation are holy." And it is true that all Israel was called to be holy. But Korah is using that truth to attack the order God had established. He does not want holiness. He wants the priesthood. Moses' response is telling. He falls on his face. He does not defend himself, but leaves the matter to the LORD. And the test is a matter of approach: who may come near to God? God himself must choose.

The earth opens, and the rebels fall into Sheol alive. It is a terrifying judgment, and it shows how seriously God takes the offices he has set up. But the very next morning, the whole congregation complains again, accusing Moses and Aaron of killing the people of the LORD. They have learned nothing. Then comes the beautiful image of Aaron, the priest they had just rejected, running into the midst of the plague with a censer of incense and standing between the dead and the living. The plague stops. The mediator they scorned saves them.

STEP 5

Connection

Jude 11 warns against the "rebellion of Korah." Hebrews 5:4 says that no one takes the honor of the priesthood for himself, but only when called by God, as Aaron was. Jesus is the greater priest who stands between the living and the dead, not with a censer but with his own blood (Hebrews 9:12). Paul says that "there is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus" (1 Timothy 2:5).

STEP 6

Application

Think about the tassels. What is one simple reminder you can put in your daily life to help you remember God's commands?

Examine whether any grumbling about leaders in your life has a root of pride.

Thank God for the mediator who stands between you and judgment.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for being the mediator who stands between the living and the dead.

Ask him to keep you from the pride of Korah.

Ask him to help you remember his commands in all that you do.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 24

"Know that the LORD, he is God! It is he who made us, and we are his; we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture."

PSALM 100:3

DAY 163 · WEEK 24

Numbers 17:1-19:22

Aaron's rod buds; priestly dues; the red heifer

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 78 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 17:1-19:22. These chapters finish the story of the challenge to Aaron, describe the duties of the priests and Levites, and give the strange law of the red heifer. Read the middle chapter for its theme of provision, and the last for its theme of cleansing.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the rebellion of Korah, the question of who may approach God has to be settled for good. Chapter 17 does this with a sign: twelve staffs are placed before the ark overnight, and only Aaron's blossoms. Chapter 18 describes what the priests and Levites receive for their support, and chapter 19 describes a ritual for cleansing from contact with the dead, using the ashes of a red heifer.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Twelve staffs, one for each tribe, are laid before the LORD in the tent of meeting (17:1-7).
2. "Behold, the staff of Aaron for the house of Levi had sprouted and put forth buds and produced blossoms, and it bore ripe almonds" (17:8).
3. The staff is put back before the testimony as a sign to the rebels (17:10).
4. The people cry, "Behold, we perish, we are lost, we are all lost!" (17:12).
5. The priests and Levites have no inheritance in the land: "I am your portion and your inheritance among the people of Israel" (18:20).
6. The Levites receive the tithe, and they give a tithe of the tithe to the priests (18:21-32).

7. A red heifer without blemish is slaughtered outside the camp, and burned with cedar, hyssop, and scarlet yarn (19:1-10).
8. The ashes are mixed with water to cleanse anyone who has touched a dead body (19:11-22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Aaron's staff is a picture of life from death. A dry stick, cut from a tree, put in a dark tent overnight, bursts into buds, flowers, and ripe almonds. It is a miracle that shows the choice of God, and it also gives a symbol of resurrection. The staff was dead wood, and it lived. The one God has chosen is the one who brings life.

The sign settles the question, and it also shows the people's fear. They had been grumbling that Moses and Aaron were killing them, and now they say, "We are lost!" The proper answer to that fear is in the next chapter, where God sets out the provision for the priesthood. The priests will bear the iniquity of the sanctuary. They stand between God's holiness and the people's sin, so that the people do not die by coming too near.

The statement in 18:20 is one of the loveliest in the book. The priests and Levites will have no land. "I am your portion and your inheritance." It sounds like a loss, but it is the greatest gift. The ones closest to God have God himself. The psalmist later says, "The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup" (Psalm 16:5).

The red heifer is the most puzzling ritual in the law. It involves a spotless animal sacrificed outside the camp, burned, and its ashes used for cleansing. It is a rite for dealing with death, the great defilement. A priest who prepares the ashes becomes unclean himself, a paradox that the rabbis later noted. The one who cleanses others is made unclean by the work.

The common thread through these chapters is that God provides what is needed to live in his presence. He provides a priest who is chosen and living, a portion that is himself, and a cleansing for the effects of death. Each of these looks ahead to Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the one who rose from the dead, the true budding rod. Hebrews 9:13-14 says, "If the blood of goats and bulls, and the sprinkling of defiled persons with the ashes of a heifer, sanctify for the purification of the flesh, how much more will the blood of Christ… purify our conscience from dead works." Hebrews 13:12 says that Jesus suffered outside the gate. Paul says that Christ is "the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep" (1 Corinthians 15:20).

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on the statement, “I am your portion.” Ask whether God himself is enough for you.

Thank God for the life that comes out of death, in Christ and in your own story.

Read Hebrews 9:13-14 and pray for the cleansing of your conscience from dead works.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what it means that he is your portion and inheritance.
- Thank him for the life that comes out of death in Jesus.
- Ask him to cleanse your conscience and let you live without fear.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 24

“Know that the LORD, he is God! It is he who made us, and we are his; we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture.”

PSALM 100:3

DAY 164 · WEEK 24

Numbers 20:1-21:35

Miriam dies; the rock; the bronze serpent, look and live

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 72 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 20:1-21:35. This reading includes Moses' great failure at Meribah, the death of Miriam and Aaron, and the story of the bronze serpent. Read slowly, and notice how one story leads into the next.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Thirty-eight years have passed, and a new generation stands at Kadesh again. The first generation has largely died. Miriam dies, the people complain about water, and Moses and Aaron sin at the rock. Edom refuses passage. Aaron dies on Mount Hor. Then Israel complains again, and God sends fiery serpents, and then provides a way of healing. The chapters end with the first victories in Transjordan.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Miriam dies and is buried at Kadesh (20:1).
2. The people quarrel with Moses about water, saying, "Why have you brought the assembly of the LORD into this wilderness, that we should die here?" (20:3-5).
3. God says, "Take the staff... and tell the rock before their eyes to yield its water" (20:8).
4. Moses says, "Hear now, you rebels: shall we bring water for you out of this rock?" and strikes the rock twice (20:10-11).
5. God says, "Because you did not believe in me, to uphold me as holy in the eyes of the people of Israel, therefore you shall not bring this assembly into the land" (20:12).
6. Aaron dies on Mount Hor, and his garments are put on Eleazar (20:22-29).

7. The people speak against God and Moses: “We loathe this worthless food.” The LORD sends fiery serpents (21:4-6).

8. God says, “Make a fiery serpent and set it on a pole, and everyone who is bitten, when he sees it, shall live” (21:8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The sin of Moses at the rock is subtle, and it is easy to underestimate. God told him to speak to the rock. Instead, Moses struck it twice, and he said, “Shall we bring water for you out of this rock?” He took the credit that belonged to God. He struck instead of speaking, repeating an earlier command from Exodus 17. And he spoke in anger. The punishment seems severe, but leaders are held to a higher standard, and Moses had misrepresented God to the people. God had described himself as gracious, and Moses showed him as harsh.

The point is a sobering one: even Moses, the meekest man on earth, could fail. No human leader can bring the people into the promised land. The law cannot do it. Only another Joshua, only a greater leader, can.

The bronze serpent is among the strangest and most important stories in the Bible. The people have been bitten by snakes because of their sin. God does not remove the snakes. Instead, he gives a remedy that requires only a look. The cure is a serpent on a pole, the image of the very thing that is killing them. The ones who look live. There is no medicine, no effort, no payment. The simplest act of faith saves.

It is a story about how salvation works. The people had to believe that looking at a bronze snake would heal them. It is foolish by any natural reasoning. But God’s cure is often a matter of faith in his word, not an act of strength. “Everyone who is bitten, when he sees it, shall live.”

The progress from the death of Aaron to the lifting of the serpent to the first victories shows that God’s work continues even when leaders fail and die. The people move on toward the land, led by a God who does not die.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “As Moses lifted up the serpent in the wilderness, so must the Son of Man be lifted up, that whoever believes in him may have eternal life” (John 3:14-15). The cross is the pole, and looking is believing. Paul says, “Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us” (Galatians 3:13). 1 Corinthians 10:4 says that the rock was Christ, who was struck once and now gives living water freely (John 7:37-38).

STEP 6

Application

Think about what it means to “look and live.” Spend a few minutes looking to Christ on the cross.

Ask whether you have ever taken credit for something God did. Give it back.

Pray for leaders who have failed, and thank God that his work does not depend on any one person.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Look to Jesus lifted up, and tell him what you need healed.
- Confess where you have taken credit that belongs to God.
- Thank him that his work goes on despite our failure.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 24

“Know that the LORD, he is God! It is he who made us, and we are his; we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture.”

PSALM 100:3

DAY 165 · WEEK 24

Numbers 22:1-24:25

Balaam, God's sovereignty over a false prophet

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 88 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 22:1-24:25. This is the story of Balaam, the prophet hired to curse Israel who can only bless them. It is full of irony and humor, and also one of the most important prophecies of the Messiah in the Old Testament. Notice who sees what.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel has camped on the plains of Moab, east of the Jordan, opposite Jericho. Balak, the king of Moab, is afraid of them. He hires Balaam, a diviner from Mesopotamia, to curse Israel. God will not let him. Balaam goes, and three times he tries to curse, and three times he blesses. The story is told from a distance. Israel never hears of it, but God is fighting for them without their knowledge.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Balak says, "He whom you bless is blessed, and he whom you curse is cursed" (22:6).
2. God tells Balaam, "You shall not go with them. You shall not curse the people, for they are blessed" (22:12).
3. Balaam goes with Balak's men, and the donkey sees the angel of the LORD three times before Balaam does (22:21-35).
4. The donkey speaks: "What have I done to you, that you have struck me these three times?" (22:28).
5. Balaam says, "I cannot go beyond the command of the LORD my God to do less or more" (22:18).

6. “God is not man, that he should lie, or a son of man, that he should change his mind” (23:19).
7. “He has not beheld misfortune in Jacob, nor has he seen trouble in Israel. The LORD their God is with them” (23:21).
8. “I see him, but not now; I behold him, but not near: a star shall come out of Jacob, and a scepter shall rise out of Israel” (24:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The story of Balaam is comic and serious at the same time. A prophet-for-hire, who is hoping for a large payment, is outwitted by his own donkey. The animal sees the angel of the LORD, and the professional seer does not. He is more eager for money than for truth. The irony is complete when the donkey speaks and Balaam answers it as though it were normal to argue with a donkey.

The deeper point is that no one can curse those whom God has blessed. Balak thinks that the right words, from the right person, in the right place, can turn God’s favor away. But God’s blessing is not a thing to be manipulated. “How can I curse whom God has not cursed?” (23:8). The blessing was given in the covenant with Abraham, and it will not be undone by any spell.

The oracle in 23:19 is among the clearest statements of God’s faithfulness: “God is not man, that he should lie.” He does not change his mind the way people do. When he promises, he does it. The people do not know any of this is happening, which is the beauty of it. While Israel sleeps in their tents, God defends them.

The last oracle, in 24:17, is the high point. Balaam, who came to curse, ends by announcing a coming king: “a star shall come out of Jacob, and a scepter shall rise out of Israel.” It looks ahead to David, who crushed Moab, and beyond David to the final King. The oracle is spoken by a pagan prophet, whose own heart is not changed. God can use anyone to speak his word, even one who does not love him.

The tragedy of Balaam is that he knew all this and still ended badly. In the next chapter, you will see how Balaam’s counsel led Israel into sin.

STEP 5

Connection

The magi who followed a star to Bethlehem (Matthew 2:2) probably knew this prophecy. Jesus is called “the bright morning star” in Revelation 22:16. Paul says that “if God is for us, who can be against us?” (Romans 8:31), and “nothing… will be able to separate us from the

love of God" (Romans 8:38-39). Peter and Jude warn about the way of Balaam, which loves gain from wrongdoing (2 Peter 2:15; Jude 11).

STEP 6

Application

Remember that no curse can undo what God has blessed in Christ. Take comfort in that if you are afraid.

Ask whether you are ever more concerned with reward than with truth, like Balaam.

Thank God that he fights for you even when you are unaware of it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that those he has blessed cannot be cursed.
- Thank him for the Star who came out of Jacob.
- Ask him to keep you from loving gain more than truth.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 24

"Know that the LORD, he is God! It is he who made us, and we are his; we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture."

PSALM 100:3

DAY 166 · WEEK 24

Psalm 99

The LORD reigns; holy is he

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Psalm · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 99. This is the last of a short series of psalms that proclaim "the LORD reigns." Read it for its repeated refrain, "Holy is he," and notice how Moses, Aaron, and Samuel appear.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 99 is a psalm of praise to the LORD as king. It has three sections, each ending with a refrain about God's holiness. Unlike the more joyful psalms, this one stresses awe and reverence. It appears here because the story of Numbers has shown what happens when people forget that the God who lives among them is holy. It also mentions Moses and Aaron, the leaders of the wilderness generation.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD reigns; let the peoples tremble! He sits enthroned upon the cherubim; let the earth quake!" (v. 1).
2. "The LORD is great in Zion; he is exalted over all the peoples" (v. 2).
3. "Let them praise your great and awesome name! Holy is he!" (v. 3).
4. "The King in his might loves justice. You have established equity; you have executed justice and righteousness in Jacob" (v. 4).
5. "Exalt the LORD our God; worship at his footstool! Holy is he!" (v. 5).
6. "Moses and Aaron were among his priests, Samuel also was among those who called upon his name" (v. 6).
7. "You were a forgiving God to them, but an avenger of their wrongdoings" (v. 8).

8 “Exalt the LORD our God, and worship at his holy mountain; for the LORD our God is holy!” (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The refrain, “Holy is he,” gives the psalm its shape. The first section celebrates God’s rule over the nations, the second his love of justice, and the third his dealings with his people in history. Each ends with the same note. Holiness is not one attribute among many. It is the character that sets God apart from everything else, the quality that makes his power safe and his justice trustworthy.

It is notable that holiness and justice go together here. The “King in his might loves justice.” A holy God is not just distant and awesome. He cares about equity. His holiness shows itself in how he rules, which is fairly and truly.

The third section is the most important for this unit. It remembers Moses, Aaron, and Samuel, who called on the LORD, and says that he answered them. He spoke to them in the pillar of cloud. This is a reference to the wilderness generation. The psalm then says something that holds together the whole book of Numbers: “You were a forgiving God to them, but an avenger of their wrongdoings.” Both are true. God forgave Israel at Kadesh, and God also let a generation die in the wilderness. He is merciful, and he is holy. Neither cancels the other.

This is a difficult balance to keep. We tend to emphasize one side and neglect the other. The psalm holds both. It encourages us to approach God as forgiving and to remember that he is holy. This is exactly what Moses prayed in Exodus 34. The same pairing appears in the apostles: grace and truth, kindness and severity.

After a week of reading about people who tested God, it is good to end with a psalm that tells us to worship him at his footstool.

STEP 5

Connection

In Isaiah 6, the seraphim cry, “Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts,” and John says that Isaiah saw Christ’s glory (John 12:41). Revelation 4:8 repeats the cry before the throne. Paul says, “Note then the kindness and the severity of God” (Romans 11:22). Peter writes, “You shall be holy, for I am holy” (1 Peter 1:16). Hebrews 12:28-29 calls us to worship with reverence and awe.

STEP 6

Application

Read the psalm aloud, and pause at each “Holy is he.” Think about what holiness means to you.

Ask whether you have emphasized God’s mercy at the expense of his holiness, or the other way around.

Thank God for his forgiveness, and ask him to make you holy.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Worship the LORD as holy, in your own words.
- Thank him that he forgives and is also just.
- Ask him to teach you reverence and awe.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 24

“Know that the LORD, he is God! It is he who made us, and we are his; we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture.”

PSALM 100:3

DAY 167 · WEEK 24

Psalm 100

Make a joyful noise, all the earth as God's people

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Psalm · 5 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 100. It is one of the shortest and most familiar psalms. Read it slowly, as a closing song for the week, and notice the commands and the reasons.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 100 is titled "A Psalm for giving thanks." It was probably sung when worshipers entered the temple courts with their thank offerings, like the thanksgiving offerings of Leviticus 7. It is brief, with only five verses. It has been sung by Christians for centuries, often as a call to worship at the start of a service. It ends the series of "the LORD reigns" psalms with an invitation for the whole earth to join in.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Make a joyful noise to the LORD, all the earth!" (v. 1).
2. "Serve the LORD with gladness! Come into his presence with singing!" (v. 2).
3. "Know that the LORD, he is God! It is he who made us, and we are his; we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture" (v. 3).
4. "Enter his gates with thanksgiving, and his courts with praise! Give thanks to him; bless his name!" (v. 4).
5. "For the LORD is good; his steadfast love endures forever, and his faithfulness to all generations" (v. 5).
6. There are seven commands: make a joyful noise, serve, come, know, enter, give thanks, bless.

7. There are three reasons: he is God and our maker, he is our shepherd, and he is good, loving, and faithful.

8. The psalm begins with “all the earth” and ends with “all generations.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is a lesson in worship. It tells us what to do, and why. The commands are about joy, gladness, singing, thanksgiving, and praise. Worship is not meant to be a grim duty. It is meant to be glad service. The word “serve” in verse 2 is the same word used for the Levites’ work. All of life can be service, and the right attitude for it is gladness.

The reasons come in verse 3 and verse 5. First, “Know that the LORD, he is God.” Everything starts with who he is. Then, “It is he who made us, and we are his.” We did not make ourselves, and we do not belong to ourselves. This is a freeing thought. It means that we are not responsible for creating our own meaning. We were made, and we are his.

The image of sheep is especially fitting after reading Numbers. Israel were a flock, led by the cloud and the shepherd’s staff of Moses. Like sheep, they wandered, complained, and got into trouble. But they had a shepherd, and the psalm reminds us that we do, too. The one who leads is good.

The last verse gives three words that sum up God’s character: good, loving, and faithful. “His steadfast love endures forever” is the refrain of the whole Old Testament. It is the word used in Exodus 34:6, the name of God in the wilderness. The people failed again and again, but his love did not.

And the psalm is for everyone: “all the earth.” The church has always taken this seriously. The God of Israel is the God of the nations, and all are invited into his gates.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “I am the good shepherd” (John 10:11), and “I will build my church” (Matthew 16:18). Peter says that believers “were straying like sheep, but have now returned to the Shepherd and Overseer of your souls” (1 Peter 2:25). Paul says that all things were created through Christ and for him (Colossians 1:16). Revelation 7:9-10 shows people from every nation joining the worship around the throne.

STEP 6

Application

Say this psalm aloud as a prayer of thanks. Name three specific things for which you are thankful.

Remember that you were made by God and belong to him. Let that settle your restlessness.

Invite someone to church or to a conversation about Christ this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Enter God's gates with thanksgiving, naming specific things you are thankful for.
- Thank him that you are the sheep of his pasture.
- Praise him that his faithfulness reaches to every generation.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 24

"Know that the LORD, he is God! It is he who made us, and we are his; we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture."

PSALM 100:3

DAY 168 · WEEK 24

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 100:3 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Know that the LORD, he is God! It is he who made us, and we are his; we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture."

PSALM 100:3

REST

Meditation

After a week of reading about rebellion, judgment, and the long wandering of the wilderness generation, Psalm 100:3 is a place to rest. It tells you who God is, and who you are.

"Know that the LORD, he is God." The verse begins with an instruction to know. Knowledge here is more than information. It is acknowledgment, the settled recognition of who is God and who is not. Much of Israel's trouble in the wilderness came from forgetting this.

"It is he who made us, and we are his." Two ideas come together: creation and belonging. God made us, so we depend on him for life. And we are his, so we are cared for. We do not have to prove ourselves or earn a place. Our identity rests on his making and his claim.

"We are his people." The phrase comes from the covenant: "I will take you to be my people, and I will be your God" (Exodus 6:7). It is a corporate identity, not only a private one. We belong to a people.

“And the sheep of his pasture.” Sheep are helpless and prone to wander. A shepherd leads them to food and water, protects them from wolves, and finds them when they are lost. The image describes how God treated Israel in the wilderness, even when they did not deserve it.

For the Christian, the verse finds its full meaning in Jesus, the good shepherd who lays down his life for the sheep (John 10:11). He knows his own and calls them by name, and no one can snatch them out of his hand (John 10:28).

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you followed Israel through more of the wilderness. You read the laws that look ahead to the land, and the rebellion of Korah, which was answered by the earth opening and by Aaron standing between the living and the dead. You saw Aaron’s staff bud, learned that the priests have God himself as their inheritance, and read the puzzling law of the red heifer. You read of Moses’ failure at the rock, the death of Miriam and Aaron, and the bronze serpent that healed all who looked. You heard the story of Balaam, the prophet who could only bless, and the prophecy of the star out of Jacob. In the Psalms, you read Psalm 99, which holds God’s forgiveness and holiness together, and Psalm 100, a song of thanks. The week taught that God preserves his plan despite human failure, and that his chosen mediator saves.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Aaron stood between the living and the dead with a censer of incense, and the plague stopped. How does this picture help you understand what Jesus does for you?

The people were healed by looking at the bronze serpent. What does this story teach you about how faith works, and what do you need to look at today?

Psalm 100 says, “It is he who made us, and we are his.” How would it change your week to remember that you belong to God?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he made you and that you are his.

Thank Jesus, the good shepherd who lays down his life.

Rest in him today.

DAY 169 · WEEK 25

Numbers 25:1-27:23

Baal of Peor; Phinehas; the second census; Joshua commissioned

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 77 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 25:1-27:23. This reading includes a terrible sin at Baal of Peor, the zeal of Phinehas, a new census, the daughters of Zelophehad, and the commissioning of Joshua. Notice the way the story turns from failure to a new beginning.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel is still on the plains of Moab. After Balaam's oracles, you might expect everything to be well, but chapter 25 tells how the people joined in the worship of Baal of Peor and with Moabite women. A plague breaks out. Chapter 26 then begins a new census of the next generation, which is a way of marking that the old generation has gone. Chapter 27 deals with the inheritance rights of women and the appointment of Moses' successor.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "While Israel lived in Shittim, the people began to whore with the daughters of Moab" (25:1).
2. They join in the worship of Baal of Peor, and the LORD's anger is kindled (25:2-3).
3. Phinehas, the son of Eleazar, takes a spear and kills an Israelite man and a Midianite woman (25:6-8).
4. The plague stops, with 24,000 dead, and God makes a covenant of peace with Phinehas and his descendants (25:9-13).
5. A new census is taken, and "among these there was not one of those listed by Moses and Aaron… except Caleb… and Joshua" (26:64-65).

6. The five daughters of Zelophehad ask for their father's inheritance, since he had no sons (27:1-4).
7. God says, "The daughters of Zelophehad are right" and makes a law for the inheritance of daughters (27:5-11).
8. Moses asks God to appoint a leader, and God says, "Take Joshua the son of Nun, a man in whom is the Spirit" (27:15-23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The sin of Baal of Peor shows how Israel's most dangerous enemy is not the army of a neighboring king but the attraction of other gods. Balaam, who could not curse Israel, found another way: he advised Balak to send women to seduce the Israelite men into idolatry (31:16). What a hired curse could not do, temptation did. The people fall into sexual immorality and the worship of a false god, the two sins that regularly appear together in the Bible. The plague that follows shows the seriousness of the offense.

Phinehas' action is hard to read. His zeal for God's honor stops the plague, and God commends him. But it is a violent act, in a setting where the nation was under the covenant penalties of the theocracy. It is not a model for private revenge. It shows the principle that when the community is polluted by sin, someone must stand in the gap. The promise of a "covenant of peace" to Phinehas is a reminder that even in judgment, God works through faithful servants.

The new census marks the end of the old generation. "Not one" was left except Caleb and Joshua. It is a quiet but powerful way of confirming God's word: what he said at Kadesh has come true. The people who feared the giants are gone, and their children are numbered. God keeps his word, both in judgment and in promise.

The story of the daughters of Zelophehad is a bright spot. The five sisters speak up in faith, believing that the land will be given and wanting a share in it. They come forward at a time when the old generation has just been shown to have lost its vision. Moses brings their case to God, and God says, "They are right." The inheritance laws are changed to include them. It is a case of faith being rewarded and the justice of God extending to those who might be overlooked.

The chapter ends with the commissioning of Joshua. Moses will not lead Israel into the land, and so a successor is appointed. He is a man "in whom is the Spirit," and he is publicly ordained with the laying on of hands.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul warns the Corinthians about the sin at Peor (1 Corinthians 10:8). Revelation 2:14 refers to the teaching of Balaam. Psalm 106:30-31 says that Phinehas' action was "counted to him as righteousness." Jesus, whose name is the Greek form of Joshua's, is the greater leader who brings his people into the true rest (Hebrews 4:8-9). The daughters of Zelophehad point forward to the truth that in Christ, there is "neither male nor female" in the inheritance (Galatians 3:28-29).

STEP 6

Application

Think about where you are most vulnerable to temptation, and take a concrete step to guard it.

Take heart from the daughters of Zelophehad. Ask God for something in faith, believing that he will keep his promises.

Pray for the next generation of leaders in your church, that they would be filled with the Spirit.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to guard your heart against rival loves.
- Thank him for keeping his word across generations.
- Pray for leaders filled with his Spirit.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 25

"And in the wilderness, where you saw how the LORD your God carried you, as a man carries his son, all the way that you went until you came to this place."

DEUTERONOMY 1:31

DAY 170 · WEEK 25

Numbers 28:1-30:16

The appointed offerings; the feasts; vows

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 76 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 28:1-30:16. These chapters give a calendar of offerings and the laws of vows. They may seem repetitive after the earlier readings in Leviticus, so read them with this question: why would God repeat this to a new generation?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The first generation has died, and a new generation stands on the edge of the land. Moses restates the regular offerings and festivals to them. The daily offering, the Sabbath, the monthly new moon, and the annual feasts are all laid out, with their required sacrifices. Chapter 30 then deals with vows: who can make them, and who can annul them. The point is to prepare the people for life in the land, where worship will be part of daily rhythm.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Command the people of Israel and say to them, My food offering, my pleasing aroma, you shall be careful to offer to me at its appointed time" (28:2).
2. The daily offering is two lambs, one in the morning and one at twilight (28:3-8).
3. The Sabbath offering doubles the daily offering (28:9-10).
4. A monthly offering is made at the new moon (28:11-15).
5. Passover and Unleavened Bread are in the first month (28:16-25), the Feast of Weeks follows (28:26-31).
6. The seventh month has the Feast of Trumpets, the Day of Atonement, and the Feast of Booths (29:1-40).

7. “If a man vows a vow to the LORD, or swears an oath to bind himself by a pledge, he shall not break his word. He shall do according to all that proceeds out of his mouth” (30:2).

8. A father or husband may annul the vow of a daughter or wife under certain conditions (30:3-16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The repeated calendar of offerings is for a new generation. The people who stood at Sinai are gone, and their children need to hear the law again. It is a lesson in how faith is passed on. Every generation must be taught. The things God has commanded do not become unimportant because they were said once.

The daily offering is the foundation of the schedule. Every morning and every evening, a lamb was offered. Everything else, the Sabbath, the new moons, the feasts, was added on top of this daily rhythm. The sense is that the whole of life is lived under the sign of sacrifice. At the beginning and end of each day, God is acknowledged and sin is covered.

The calendar also builds toward the seventh month. The feasts cluster there, the Trumpets, the Day of Atonement, and Booths. The seventh month is the climax of the year, and it moves from the trumpet of awakening, through the cleansing of atonement, to the joy of the harvest. It is a movement that the church has always seen as a picture of the whole story of salvation.

The laws about vows come next. The principle in 30:2 is clear: a person must keep his word. Because a vow is made to the LORD, it is not something to be taken lightly. This is a hard word in an age when promises are cheap. The details about fathers and husbands annulling vows reflect the family structure of ancient Israel, and they show that vows were taken seriously enough to need regulation.

Behind all of it is the idea that worship is meant to be ordered. God does not leave it to our moods. He gives times, and he calls us to be faithful to them. This is not legalism. It is the discipline that keeps love alive.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the Lamb who was slain once for all, ending the need for daily sacrifices (Hebrews 10:11-14). Paul tells believers to “present your bodies as a living sacrifice” (Romans 12:1), and Hebrews 13:15 calls for a continual sacrifice of praise. Jesus taught, “Let what you say be

simply Yes or No" (Matthew 5:37), echoing the importance of keeping one's word. Colossians 2:17 says that the festivals are "a shadow of the things to come."

STEP 6

Application

Consider the daily rhythm of your own life. Do you begin and end the day with God?

Think about any promise you have made and not kept. Bring it to God and make it right.

Thank God that the daily sacrifice has been fulfilled in Christ, and offer him your praise today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that he is worthy of worship at every time.
- Ask him to make you faithful to your word and to time with him.
- Thank Jesus, the Lamb who took away your sin once for all.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 25

"And in the wilderness, where you saw how the LORD your God carried you, as a man carries his son, all the way that you went until you came to this place."

DEUTERONOMY 1:31

DAY 171 · WEEK 25

Numbers 31:1-32:42

War with Midian; Reuben and Gad settle east of the Jordan

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 81 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 31:1-32:42. These chapters describe the war against Midian and the request of two and a half tribes to settle east of the Jordan. The first is difficult material. Read it with care and with the context of the whole book in mind.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

God had told Moses that after the matter of Peor, he would take vengeance on the Midianites, and then he would be gathered to his people. Chapter 31 describes the campaign. Chapter 32 then turns to the tribes of Reuben and Gad, and half of Manasseh, who have large herds and see that the land east of the Jordan is good for livestock. They ask to settle there. Moses is alarmed, because it sounds like the sin of the spies all over again.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God tells Moses, “Avenge the people of Israel on the Midianites. Afterward you shall be gathered to your people” (31:2).
2. Twelve thousand men, a thousand from each tribe, go out with Phinehas and the holy vessels (31:3-6).
3. They kill every male, including the five kings and Balaam son of Beor (31:7-8).
4. Moses is angry that the women who caused Israel to sin at Peor were spared (31:14-16).
5. The soldiers and anything that touched death must be purified (31:19-24).
6. The plunder is divided between the soldiers and the congregation, with a tribute to the LORD and to the Levites (31:25-47).
7. The tribes of Reuben and Gad ask to settle east of the Jordan (32:1-5).

8 Moses says, “Shall your brothers go to the war while you sit here?” and then agrees on the condition that they fight with the others until the land is taken (32:6-33). He warns, “Be sure your sin will find you out” (32:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The war with Midian is one of the more troubling stories in Scripture, and it deserves to be read honestly. It is presented as a judgment on a people who had deliberately tried to destroy Israel’s faith, and it is carried out as a holy war under God’s explicit command, under the leadership of the priest, and with the sacred vessels. It was not a general permission for violence. It was a specific judgment, in a specific time, on a specific people who had led Israel into idolatry.

Notice the attention to purity. The soldiers must be cleansed after the battle, and the plunder is purified. The text is clear that war is a defiling thing, even when commanded. The gold given to the LORD, 16,750 shekels, is accompanied by the confession that none of the men has been lost. These are the marks of a people who understand that they are not simply conquerors but servants.

The story of the eastern tribes is an important lesson about community responsibility. Reuben and Gad do not want to cross over. Moses’ first response is sharp, because he sees in it the same fear that destroyed their fathers. But the tribes explain that they will go before their brothers, armed, until the whole land is settled. Moses accepts, and he warns them that their word is binding before the LORD.

The sentence, “Be sure your sin will find you out,” is a proverb of its own. It is about the certainty that hidden or neglected obligations eventually come to light. Obligation to the community, kept or broken, is a matter of faithfulness to God.

The shape of the chapters is a warning against comfort. The tribes had found a good place and were tempted to stop short of the promise. We, too, can settle for good things this side of the Jordan. The call is to join our brothers in the greater work until it is done.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 4:11 says, “Let us therefore strive to enter that rest.” Paul tells believers to carry each other’s burdens (Galatians 6:2) and compares the church to a body (1 Corinthians 12). The warning to the eastern tribes echoes Jesus’ words about those who put their hand to the plow and look back (Luke 9:62). The war of Midian points to the ultimate battle against evil, which Christ has won (Colossians 2:15).

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether you have settled for something good that is short of God's best for you.

Think about your obligations to your community. Are you carrying your share?

Consider the seriousness of sin. "Be sure your sin will find you out." Confess anything hidden.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from settling short of his best.
- Pray for those you walk beside, that you would be faithful to them.
- Thank Christ for winning the final victory over evil.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 25

"And in the wilderness, where you saw how the LORD your God carried you, as a man carries his son, all the way that you went until you came to this place."

DEUTERONOMY 1:31

DAY 172 · WEEK 25

Numbers 33:1-34:29

Stages of the journey; boundaries of the land

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 65 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 33:1-34:29. The first chapter is a travel diary of the entire journey from Egypt. The second sets out the boundaries of the land. Read the first as a testimony to God's faithfulness, and the second as a promise coming close.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel is about to cross the Jordan. Before they do, Moses records every stage of the journey from Egypt to the plains of Moab. There are forty-two stops. The record is written "by command of the LORD." Then God defines the borders of the land, names the leaders who will divide it, and gives instructions for the conquest.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Moses wrote down their starting places, stage by stage, by command of the LORD" (33:2).
2. The list begins with Rameses and ends with the plains of Moab by the Jordan (33:3-49).
3. Some of the stops are well known: the sea, Marah, Elim, Rephidim, Sinai, Kibroth-hattaavah, Kadesh (33:8-37).
4. Aaron died on Mount Hor at the age of 123 (33:38-39).
5. "When you pass over the Jordan into the land of Canaan, then you shall drive out all the inhabitants of the land from before you" (33:51-52).
6. Failure to drive them out will make them "as barbs in your eyes and thorns in your sides" (33:55).
7. The borders of the land are described on the south, west, north, and east (34:1-12).

8 Eleazar and Joshua, with one leader from each tribe, will divide the land (34:16-29).

STEP 4

Interpretation

A list of travel stops is not what we would choose to read for inspiration, but it says something important. Forty-two stages. Each name is a place where God's people camped, and where something happened. Some were places of failure, some of provision, and some of grief. The list shows that the whole journey, even the part that felt like wasted time, was part of God's plan. "By command of the LORD," Moses wrote it down.

The record is also a way of remembering. In the Psalms, the people are repeatedly told to recall the journey. This list gives a map for memory. If we want to understand God's faithfulness, we need to look back over the stages of our own lives and see how he led us. Few of us remember every stage. But God does.

The shift to the land of Canaan marks the end of the wilderness. For the first time since leaving Egypt, the people are given a goal with edges. The borders are described in detail, because the land is a gift with specific limits. It is real, and it is theirs.

The warning in 33:55 is sobering. If they do not drive out the inhabitants, those left will become "barbs in your eyes and thorns in your sides." The danger was not military but spiritual. Peoples who worshiped other gods would be a constant temptation. The book of Judges will show how it came true.

The assignment of leaders to divide the land is a final note of order. Eleazar the priest and Joshua the leader will work with one chief from each tribe. The land is not seized by individuals but received by the community, under the guidance of God's chosen leaders.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 11:13-16 describes the patriarchs as people who "confessed that they were strangers and exiles on the earth" and who longed for a heavenly country. Paul says that "all things work together for good for those who love God" (Romans 8:28), including the wanderings. Peter describes believers as "sojourners and exiles" (1 Peter 2:11). The new Jerusalem has boundaries too, and its dimensions are given in Revelation 21:15-17.

STEP 6

Application

Take a few minutes to list the stages of your own journey with God. Where have you seen his faithfulness?

Ask whether there is a “thorn in your side,” something you have left unresolved. Take a step to deal with it.

Thank God that your journey has a destination, and that he is leading you there.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for leading you stage by stage, remembering a step you can name.
- Ask him to help you deal with the “thorns” you have left behind.
- Look forward with him to the land he has promised.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 25

“And in the wilderness, where you saw how the LORD your God carried you, as a man carries his son, all the way that you went until you came to this place.”

DEUTERONOMY 1:31

DAY 173 · WEEK 25

Numbers 35:1-36:13

Levitical cities, cities of refuge; inheritance laws

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 35:1-36:13. The book ends with cities for the Levites, cities of refuge for those who kill accidentally, and a final ruling about inheritance. Read the cities of refuge slowly, as they are rich in meaning.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The tribes are about to receive their land. The Levites, who have no tribal territory, are to be given forty-eight cities scattered among the others. Six of these are designated as cities of refuge, places where a person who has killed someone accidentally can flee and be safe. The book concludes with a follow-up to the case of the daughters of Zelophehad, since the tribes were concerned that their inheritance might pass from tribe to tribe.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The Levites receive forty-eight cities with pasturelands (35:1-8).
2. Six are cities of refuge: three east of the Jordan, three west (35:9-15).
3. The one who kills by accident may flee to a city of refuge and be safe from “the avenger of blood” (35:11-12).
4. A murderer, however, may not take refuge, and must be put to death on the testimony of two or more witnesses (35:16-34).
5. The manslayer must stay in the city of refuge “until the death of the high priest” (35:25, 28).
6. “You shall not pollute the land in which you live, for blood pollutes the land, and no atonement can be made for the land for the blood that is shed in it, except by the blood

of the one who shed it" (35:33).

7. "You shall not defile the land in which you live, in the midst of which I dwell, for I the LORD dwell in the midst of the people of Israel" (35:34).

8. The tribes are to keep their inheritance, and women who inherit must marry within their tribe (36:1-12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The cities of refuge are one of the most beautiful provisions in the law. In the ancient world, if someone was killed, a relative was expected to take revenge. This cycle could consume whole families. God provides an alternative: places where a person who killed by accident could run and be safe until a fair trial. The law distinguishes between murder and manslaughter, and it protects the innocent while still taking life seriously.

The cities were spread out so that no one would be too far from one. The roads to them were kept in good repair, according to later tradition. They were open to everyone, Israelite or foreigner. The point is accessibility. A person in flight, with an avenger at his heels, could reach safety without delay.

The detail about the high priest is surprising. The manslayer must stay in the city until the high priest dies, and then he may go home. It seems arbitrary at first, but it contains a profound idea. The death of the high priest atones. His death is the end of the exile. It makes a way home for those who were under restraint.

The reason for the law is given in the last verses of chapter 35. Bloodshed pollutes the land, and the land cannot be cleansed except by the shedding of the murderer's blood. God dwells in the land, so its purity is a matter of life and death. The same principle runs through the whole of Leviticus: where God dwells, sin must be dealt with.

The final chapter returns to a practical matter and ends on a note of order and obedience. The daughters of Zelophehad do as they were told. The book that began with a census ends with an inheritance. After forty years, the people are ready, at least in terms of structure, to enter the land.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 6:18 speaks of those "who have fled for refuge" to lay hold of the hope set before them, and Jesus is the one in whom we find refuge. He is also the high priest whose death sets the captives free (Hebrews 9:15). Paul says, "There is therefore now no condemnation for

those who are in Christ Jesus" (Romans 8:1). Jesus prayed on the cross, "Father, forgive them, for they know not what they do" (Luke 23:34).

STEP 6

Application

Think of Christ as your city of refuge, and run to him with whatever guilt you carry.

Consider whether you hold a grudge against someone, and whether you could extend mercy.

Thank God that the death of the great high priest has opened the way home.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Flee to Christ as your refuge, and tell him what you are running from.
- Ask him to keep you from the cycle of vengeance.
- Ask him to make you quick to show mercy.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 25

"And in the wilderness, where you saw how the LORD your God carried you, as a man carries his son, all the way that you went until you came to this place."

DEUTERONOMY 1:31

DAY 174 · WEEK 25

Deuteronomy 1:1-3:29

Moses recounts the journey, covenant history

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 81 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 1:1-3:29. A new book begins, and it is a series of sermons by Moses. Notice how he looks backward to the journey from Sinai, and what he says to the new generation about what their parents did.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Deuteronomy means "second law." It takes place on the plains of Moab, in the last weeks of Moses' life. Forty years have passed since the exodus. A new generation, most of whom were children or unborn at Sinai, stands ready to cross the Jordan. Moses preaches to them in a series of speeches. The first section, which you read today, is a historical review: it recalls how God led Israel from Horeb to this place, and why they are here and not in the land already.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "It is eleven days" journey from Horeb by the way of Mount Seir to Kadesh-barnea' (1:2).
2. "The LORD our God said to us in Horeb, You have stayed long enough at this mountain" (1:6).
3. Moses recounts how he appointed leaders to share the burden of judging (1:9-18).
4. The people refused to enter the land: "Because the LORD hated us he has brought us out of the land of Egypt" (1:27).
5. "The LORD your God... carried you, as a man carries his son, all the way that you went" (1:31).

6. Because of their unbelief, the LORD swore that none of that generation would see the land, except Caleb (1:34-36).
7. Moses was also barred from entering because of the people (1:37; 3:23-27).
8. God gives victories over Sihon and Og, and Moses sees the land from Mount Pisgah (2:26-3:29).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Moses begins by looking back, and what he says is a lesson in the right use of memory. He remembers the failures honestly, including his own burden and the people's refusal. But he also remembers God's care. The most beautiful line is 1:31: "in the wilderness, where you saw how the LORD your God carried you, as a man carries his son." Behind the story of rebellion and judgment, there was a father carrying his child.

The review has a purpose. The new generation needs to understand why they are standing east of the Jordan, and why the land is a gift and not an achievement. If they think the land is theirs by right, they will repeat their fathers' mistake. Moses tells the story so that they will learn to trust.

It also reveals the heart of the old generation's sin. They said, "Because the LORD hated us he has brought us out of Egypt." This is a shocking accusation. The very act of rescue became evidence of hatred in their minds. It is a picture of what unbelief does. It takes God's love and turns it inside out.

Moses' mention of his own exclusion from the land shows an honesty in leadership. He does not hide his failure or pretend that it was unjust. He says that God was angry with him "on your account," and that he pleaded for mercy and was refused. The leader shares the consequences of the people's sin, and in that sense he points beyond himself to one who would bear them fully.

The chapters end with Moses on the mountain, looking over the land he will not enter, and with the command to charge and encourage Joshua. The torch is passed. The people will go in, and Moses will not. But God will be with Joshua.

STEP 5

Connection

Stephen's speech in Acts 7 retells this history, and Paul preaches a similar summary in Acts 13:18, citing Deuteronomy 1:31: "he put up with them in the wilderness." Isaiah 63:9 says, "In all their affliction he was afflicted… he lifted them up and carried them all the days of old."

Jesus said, “Come to me… and I will give you rest” (Matthew 11:28). Moses looks at the land from afar, as Hebrews 11:13 says of all the faithful.

STEP 6

Application

Take time to remember how God has carried you. Write down two or three instances.

Ask whether you have ever interpreted God’s care as hostility, and tell him about it.

Think about those you are leading or teaching. How might you pass on what God has done?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for carrying you as a father carries his son, naming a time you did not know it.

Confess where you mistook his love for hatred.

Ask him to teach you to remember his works and pass them on.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 25

“And in the wilderness, where you saw how the LORD your God carried you, as a man carries his son, all the way that you went until you came to this place.”

DEUTERONOMY 1:31

DAY 175 · WEEK 25

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Deuteronomy 1:31 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And in the wilderness, where you saw how the LORD your God carried you, as a man carries his son, all the way that you went until you came to this place."

DEUTERONOMY 1:31

REST

Meditation

Deuteronomy 1:31 is a single sentence, spoken at the end of a forty-year journey, that changes how we look at the whole wilderness.

"In the wilderness." The wilderness is the place of testing and failure in the Bible. It is where Israel grumbled, rebelled, and wandered. Moses does not deny any of it. But he tells them to look again.

"Where you saw how the LORD your God carried you." The people had seen many things in the wilderness: manna, water from the rock, fire and cloud. Moses asks them to see the hidden side of the story. In all their complaining and unbelief, someone had been carrying them.

“As a man carries his son.” It is a tender picture of a father carrying a child too small or too tired to walk. It is not the image of a general leading an army. It is the image of a parent who picks up a child, who does not shame them for being weak, and who brings them all the way home.

“All the way that you went until you came to this place.” The carrying was not occasional but constant. Every step of the forty years was a step taken with God’s help. The place where they stood was the result of his faithfulness and not their strength.

For the Christian, the verse is an assurance. “He who began a good work in you will bring it to completion at the day of Jesus Christ” (Philippians 1:6). The Father who carried Israel carries his children still, through the Son who bore our sins.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you came to the end of the book of Numbers and the beginning of Deuteronomy. You read about the sin at Baal of Peor and the zeal of Phinehas, the new census that confirmed God’s word about the old generation, and the daughters of Zelophehad, who asked for an inheritance by faith. You read of Joshua’s commissioning, the calendar of offerings, the war against Midian, and the request of the eastern tribes. You read the travel record of the forty-two stages and the boundaries of the land. You learned of the cities of refuge and the death of the high priest that sets the manslayer free. Then Moses began his sermons on the plains of Moab, looking back over the journey and reminding the new generation that God had carried them. The week taught that God keeps his word in judgment and in promise, and that he is the one who carries his people.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Moses says that God carried Israel “as a man carries his son.” Where have you seen God carry you in a time you were not aware of it, and what would it mean to thank him for it?

The manslayer was freed by the death of the high priest. How does this picture deepen your understanding of what Christ’s death accomplished?

Moses recalled the past honestly, including his own failure. What do you need to remember honestly about your own journey, and how might that help you trust God for the future?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for carrying you when you did not know it.

Ask him to help you remember his faithfulness.

Rest in him, trusting him for the road ahead.

DAY 176 · WEEK 26

Psalm 78:1-39

Teaching the next generation, remembering God's works

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Psalm · 39 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 78:1-39. This is a long psalm that retells Israel's history as a lesson for the next generation. Today's section covers the exodus and the wilderness. Read it alongside what you have just finished in Numbers.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 78 is a psalm of Asaph, and it is the second longest psalm in the Psalter. It is called a "maskil," a teaching psalm. Its purpose is stated in the first verses: to tell the coming generation the glorious deeds of the LORD, so that they might set their hope in God and not be like their fathers, a stubborn and rebellious generation. Today's reading, verses 1 to 39, retells the events of Exodus and Numbers with a focus on Israel's repeated forgetfulness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Give ear, O my people, to my teaching; incline your ears to the words of my mouth!" (v. 1).
2. "We will not hide them from their children, but tell to the coming generation the glorious deeds of the LORD" (v. 4).
3. The purpose: "that they should set their hope in God and not forget the works of God, but keep his commandments" (v. 7).
4. "The Ephraimites, armed with the bow, turned back on the day of battle" (v. 9).
5. "They forgot what he had done and the wonders that he had shown them" (v. 11).
6. "He divided the sea and let them pass through it, and made the waters stand like a heap" (v. 13).

7. “Yet they sinned still more against him, rebelling against the Most High in the desert” (v. 17).

8. “But he, being compassionate, atoned for their iniquity and did not destroy them; he restrained his anger often and did not stir up all his wrath. He remembered that they were but flesh, a wind that passes and comes not again” (vv. 38-39).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm has a clear structure. It begins with the duty to teach the next generation. Then it gives the story, a long alternating pattern of God’s miracles and Israel’s rebellion. Five times in this section alone, the pattern repeats: God acts, the people forget, and God responds with both discipline and mercy. The psalm reads like a summary of Numbers.

The reason for telling the story is that memory is the cure for unbelief. The people turned back in battle, not because the enemy was strong, but because “they forgot what he had done.” When we forget God’s past faithfulness, we cannot trust his present promises. That is why Moses’ whole book of Deuteronomy is built around the word “remember.”

Look at the pattern in verses 17 to 22. The people ask for food, and they test God, saying, “Can God spread a table in the wilderness?” The question is not wrong in itself. It is that they ask it in unbelief, after seeing him divide the sea and bring water from the rock. They want to see if God can do one more thing. It is a picture of the way we treat God when we hold his past gifts at arm’s length.

The center of the section is verses 38 and 39: “He, being compassionate, atoned for their iniquity and did not destroy them.” The key word is “atoned.” God’s compassion is not just a feeling. It leads to action. He provides a covering for sin. And his reason is gentle: “He remembered that they were but flesh.” God knows our frailty. He does not forget it.

The psalm ends today’s section with a mixture of warning and comfort. We can be as stubborn as Israel, but God is more patient than we are stubborn. That is the hope we carry as we teach our children the story.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that the events of the wilderness “took place as examples for us” (1 Corinthians 10:6), and in Romans 15:4 that “whatever was written in former days was written for our instruction.” Jesus quoted this psalm’s words about manna when he said that he is the true

bread from heaven (John 6:31). Psalm 103:14 echoes verses 38 and 39: “he knows our frame; he remembers that we are dust.” Hebrews 2:17 says that Christ is a merciful high priest who made propitiation for our sins.

STEP 6

Application

Make a list of the works of God that you want to remember, and share one with a child or younger believer this week.

Ask whether there is an area where you are testing God, doubting that he can provide.

Thank God that he remembers you are dust, and that his compassion made atonement.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to help you tell the next generation of his glorious deeds.

Confess where you forget what he has done.

Thank him for compassion that remembers you are dust.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 26

“And these words that I command you today shall be on your heart. You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise.”

DEUTERONOMY 6:6-7

DAY 177 · WEEK 26

Deuteronomy 4:1-5:33

Obey the law; the Ten Commandments repeated

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 76 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 4:1-5:33. Moses turns from history to instruction. He urges Israel to obey, and he restates the Ten Commandments. Notice the reasons he gives for obedience.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Having reviewed the journey, Moses begins his second major address. The word "now" in 4:1 marks the turn: "And now, O Israel, listen to the statutes and the rules that I am teaching you." He wants the people to keep the law carefully, because it is their wisdom before the nations. Then, in chapter 5, he gathers the whole assembly and repeats the Ten Commandments given at Horeb, with some variations from the version in Exodus.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "You shall not add to the word that I command you, nor take from it" (4:2).
2. "Keep them and do them, for that will be your wisdom and your understanding in the sight of the peoples" (4:6).
3. "For what great nation is there that has a god so near to it as the LORD our God is to us, whenever we call upon him?" (4:7).
4. "You saw no form on the day that the LORD spoke to you at Horeb out of the midst of the fire" (4:15).
5. "The LORD your God is a merciful God. He will not leave you or destroy you or forget the covenant with your fathers" (4:31).
6. "Hear, O Israel, the statutes and the rules that I speak in your hearing today" (5:1).

7. The Ten Commandments are given again (5:6-21), with the Sabbath commandment grounded in the exodus: "You shall remember that you were a slave in the land of Egypt" (5:15).

8. The people say, "Go near and hear all that the LORD our God will say... and we will hear and do it" (5:27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Moses begins with a startling claim: the law is a gift that makes Israel the envy of the nations. The nations will hear these statutes and say, "Surely this great nation is a wise and understanding people." Obedience is not a burden but a witness. The law shows what a people ruled by a just and loving God would look like.

The reason is not just the laws, but the God who gave them. "What great nation has a god so near to it?" The nearness of God is the glory of Israel. The other nations had gods to be placated from afar. Israel's God spoke from the fire and called them to himself.

Moses warns against making images. At Horeb, the people heard a voice, but they saw no form. That was deliberate. A God who cannot be pictured cannot be controlled. Moses stresses that the temptation to make an image, to shape God into something we can handle, is real, and he warns of the consequences.

The restatement of the Ten Commandments in chapter 5 shows how the law was meant to be internalized. The same words that were spoken to the previous generation are now spoken to the next, in the present tense: "The LORD made this covenant not with our fathers but with us, who are all of us here alive today" (5:3). Each generation must receive the covenant as its own.

One difference from Exodus is that the Sabbath commandment gives a new reason. In Exodus, it is based on creation. Here, it is based on redemption: "You shall remember that you were a slave." The Sabbath is a gift to those who were once denied rest, and it extends rest to servants and animals.

The people's response sounds right. "We will hear and do it." But God says that he wishes they had such a heart always. Hearing and doing are the key, and the whole book will keep returning to them.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Think not that I have come to abolish the Law or the Prophets; I have not come to abolish them but to fulfill them” (Matthew 5:17). He is the visible image of the invisible God (Colossians 1:15), the “form” that Israel did not see. Paul says that the law was a guardian until Christ came (Galatians 3:24). Jesus says, “If you love me, you will keep my commandments” (John 14:15).

STEP 6

Application

Read the Ten Commandments aloud slowly. Ask which one the Spirit is pressing on you this week.

Think about how your life displays the wisdom of God to those around you.

Thank God that he is near, and that you can call upon him at any time.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that he has drawn near in Jesus.
- Ask him to write his commandments on your heart.
- Ask him to let your obedience be a witness to those around you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 26

“And these words that I command you today shall be on your heart. You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise.”

DEUTERONOMY 6:6-7

DAY 178 · WEEK 26

Deuteronomy 6:1-8:20

The Shema; love and memory; do not forget God

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 77 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 6:1-8:20. This is the heart of the book. It contains the Shema, the greatest commandment, and Moses' warnings about forgetting God in prosperity. Read chapter 6 slowly, and think about verses 4 to 9 as the center.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Moses now moves from the Ten Commandments to their meaning. These chapters begin with the greatest commandment and then apply it to life in the land. They deal with passing faith to the next generation, the dangers of prosperity, and the testing in the wilderness. The Shema, the opening words of 6:4, are recited by Jewish people daily to this day.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one" (6:4).
2. "You shall love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your might" (6:5).
3. "And these words that I command you today shall be on your heart" (6:6).
4. "You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise" (6:7).
5. "When your son asks you in time to come, What is the meaning of the testimonies… then you shall say to your son, We were Pharaoh's slaves in Egypt" (6:20-21).
6. The LORD did not set his love on Israel because they were more in number, but "because the LORD loves you and is keeping the oath that he swore to your fathers" (7:7-

8).

7. “And you shall remember the whole way that the LORD your God has led you these forty years in the wilderness, that he might humble you, testing you” (8:2).

8. “Man does not live by bread alone, but man lives by every word that comes from the mouth of the LORD” (8:3).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Shema is the center of Israel’s faith, and of the Bible’s teaching about God. “The LORD our God, the LORD is one.” There is one God, and he is the covenant God. The statement is both theological and personal. He is “our God.” And the response to him is not just assent but love, with the whole person: heart, soul, and might.

Moses ties love to obedience, and obedience to teaching. The words are to be on the heart first, before they are taught to the children. A parent cannot pass on what he does not hold. And the teaching is to happen in all of ordinary life: at home, on the road, at bedtime, at waking. It is not a classroom subject. It is the atmosphere of the household. The signs on the hand and forehead and doorposts are reminders that faith belongs to every part of life.

Then comes a warning about success. “When the LORD your God brings you into the land… take care lest you forget the LORD.” The danger is not hardship but plenty. In good times, we easily imagine that we have earned what we have. Moses says, “You shall remember the LORD your God, for it is he who gives you power to get wealth” (8:18).

Chapter 7 gives a stunning reason for God’s choice of Israel. It was not their size or strength. “The LORD set his love on you” because he loved you. There is no explanation behind love except love itself. This is grace in the Old Testament.

The wilderness years, according to chapter 8, were not wasted. God humbled and tested them to teach one lesson: “Man does not live by bread alone.” Jesus quoted it when tempted in the desert. The manna was a lesson in daily dependence. The forty years were a school of trust.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus calls the Shema “the great and first commandment” (Matthew 22:36-38), and he quotes Deuteronomy 8:3 against Satan (Matthew 4:4). Paul says that “there is one God, the Father… and one Lord, Jesus Christ” (1 Corinthians 8:6), and John says that God’s love for us was shown when “he sent his Son” (1 John 4:10). Ephesians 6:4 tells fathers to bring up their children “in the discipline and instruction of the Lord.”

STEP 6

Application

Say the Shema aloud, slowly. Ask what it would mean to love God with every part of you.

Think of one concrete way you can bring God's word into the ordinary rhythms of your home this week.

Ask whether prosperity or comfort has dulled your dependence on God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God you want to love him with all your heart, soul, and might, and where that is hard.

Ask him to keep you from forgetting him in good times.

Ask him to help you teach his words to someone else.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 26

"And these words that I command you today shall be on your heart. You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise."

DEUTERONOMY 6:6-7

DAY 179 · WEEK 26

Deuteronomy 9:1-11:32

Not by your righteousness; God's love for the patriarchs

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 85 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 9:1-11:32. Moses continues his warning about the danger of self-righteousness. He retells the story of the golden calf, and ends with a call to love and obey. Notice how often he says "not because of your righteousness."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel is about to cross the Jordan and to defeat nations stronger than themselves. Moses warns them not to think that this is because of their goodness. In fact, they have been "a stubborn people" from the day they left Egypt. He recalls the golden calf, Moses' intercession, and the second set of tablets. He closes with a call to fear and love the LORD, a promise of blessing, and the first mention of the blessing and curse to be pronounced at Gerizim and Ebal.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Know therefore that the LORD your God is not giving you this good land to possess because of your righteousness, for you are a stubborn people" (9:6).
2. "From the day you came out of the land of Egypt until you came to this place, you have been rebellious against the LORD" (9:7).
3. Moses recounts the forty days on the mountain and the golden calf, and how he fell down before the LORD for forty days and nights (9:9-29).
4. The LORD wrote the commandments again on two new tablets and put them in the ark (10:1-5).
5. "And now, Israel, what does the LORD your God require of you, but to fear the LORD your God, to walk in all his ways, to love him, to serve the LORD your God with all your

heart and with all your soul" (10:12).

6. "Circumcise therefore the foreskin of your heart, and be no longer stubborn" (10:16).
7. "He executes justice for the fatherless and the widow, and loves the sojourner, giving him food and clothing. Love the sojourner, therefore" (10:18-19).
8. "Behold, I am setting before you today a blessing and a curse" (11:26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The centerpiece of this section is the repeated phrase, "not because of your righteousness." Moses says it again and again. Israel's coming victory will not be a reward for their goodness. It will be an act of God's faithfulness to his promise and a judgment on the wickedness of the nations. The land is a gift, and it is an act of grace to a stubborn people.

The retelling of the golden calf is meant to humble. Moses recalls the very worst moment: that at the foot of the mountain where God had just spoken, the people turned to a calf. And he recalls his own intercession, forty days of prostration. Without it, God would have destroyed them. The point is not to shame, but to show that their standing before God depends on his mercy and on a mediator, and not on their record.

Then comes the great question of 10:12: "What does the LORD your God require of you?" The answer is a list, but it is all one thing: fear, walk, love, serve. The center is love. After a long section about rebellion, the call is not to a new set of rules, but to a heart. And God asks this because he has first loved them: "Yet the LORD set his heart in love on your fathers" (10:15).

The command to "circumcise your heart" in 10:16 is one of the most important phrases in the Old Testament. It shows that the real issue was never the outward mark, but the inner condition. Later, Deuteronomy 30:6 promises that God himself will do this, and Jeremiah and Ezekiel pick it up as the promise of the new covenant.

The portrait of God in 10:17-19 is striking. He is "God of gods and Lord of lords," great and awesome, who takes no bribe, and who loves the sojourner. The most powerful being in the universe is the protector of the powerless. Those who belong to him are to imitate that care.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says, "By grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works" (Ephesians 2:8-9). He writes that "circumcision is a matter of the heart, by the Spirit" (Romans 2:29). Jesus said that to love the LORD with all your heart is the great commandment, and that we are to love our neighbor, including the stranger. In Christ, God has given the new heart (Ezekiel 36:26).

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you are tempted to think that blessings come because you deserve them. Replace that thought with gratitude.

Pray 10:12 as a personal prayer. Which of the verbs, fear, walk, love, serve, do you most need this week?

Show practical love to a stranger or someone vulnerable.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that his love for you is not based on your righteousness.

Ask him to circumcise your heart.

Ask him to teach you to fear, walk with, love, and serve him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 26

"And these words that I command you today shall be on your heart. You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise."

DEUTERONOMY 6:6-7

DAY 180 · WEEK 26

Psalm 78:40-72

God's patience with rebellion; David chosen as shepherd-king

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Psalm · 33 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 78:40-72. This is the second half of the history psalm. It continues from the wilderness through the plagues of Egypt, the conquest, the failures in the land, and ends with the choice of David. Notice how the story ends.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 78 continues. Verses 40 to 72 go back over the exodus, with the plagues, and then move forward through the settlement in the land, Israel's idolatry, the capture of the ark, God's rejection of Shiloh, and his choice of Judah and David. It is a summary of the story from Exodus to 2 Samuel, and it ends with a hopeful note.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "How often they rebelled against him in the wilderness and grieved him in the desert!" (v. 40).
2. "They did not remember his power or the day when he redeemed them from the foe" (vv. 42-43).
3. The plagues of Egypt are named: blood, flies, frogs, locusts, hail, pestilence, and the death of the firstborn (vv. 44-51).
4. "Then he led out his people like sheep and guided them in the wilderness like a flock" (v. 52).
5. "Yet they tested and rebelled against the Most High God and did not keep his testimonies" (v. 56).

6. “They provoked him to anger with their high places; they moved him to jealousy with their idols” (v. 58).
7. “He forsook his dwelling at Shiloh, the tent where he dwelt among mankind, and delivered his power to captivity” (vv. 60-61).
8. “He chose David his servant and took him from the sheepfolds… to shepherd Jacob his people… With upright heart he shepherded them and guided them with his skillful hand” (vv. 70-72).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The second half of the psalm shows what happens in the land. The pattern from the wilderness continues. God brings them in, but they test him again and turn to idols. Judgment follows: the ark is captured and Shiloh falls. These are events from the period of Samuel that you will read about soon. The psalm sees all of it as a single pattern: grace, rebellion, judgment, and then, remarkably, grace again.

The surprise comes at the end. After a long account of failure, the psalm does not end with destruction. It ends with the choice of David. “He chose David his servant.” The LORD wakes up like a man who has been asleep and chooses a new shepherd for his people. The humble beginnings are important. David is taken “from the sheepfolds, from following the nursing ewes.” God’s way is to raise up the unlikely.

The picture of the king is a shepherd. “He shepherded them with upright heart and guided them with his skillful hand.” This is the model for leadership in Israel: a shepherd who cares for the flock. It is the same image that opens the wilderness section: “He led out his people like sheep.” The one who led Israel through the desert through Moses will now lead them through David.

For anyone who has read the whole story from Genesis to Deuteronomy, the psalm gives a long view. The failure is real, and God’s judgment is real, but his plan is not defeated. He is working toward the shepherd king, a descendant of David, who will lead his people perfectly.

The lesson for the next generation is that God’s faithfulness is the thread in the story. Our failures are not the point. His mercy is. That is what the children are to be taught.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the Son of David and the good shepherd (John 10:11). Matthew 9:36 says that when he saw the crowds, “he had compassion for them, because they were harassed and helpless, like sheep without a shepherd.” Ezekiel 34:23 promises that God will set one shepherd over them,

his servant David. In 1 Peter 5:4, Jesus is called the “chief Shepherd.” Hebrews 13:20 calls him “the great shepherd of the sheep.”

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on the pattern in your own story: grace, failure, discipline, and grace again. Thank God for his steadiness.

Think about who has shepherded you spiritually. Thank them, and pray for them.

Ask how you might shepherd those entrusted to you, with a pure heart and skillful hands.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus, the good shepherd who laid down his life.
- Ask God to help you tell the story of his faithfulness to those near you.
- Thank him for choosing and leading shepherds for his people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 26

“And these words that I command you today shall be on your heart. You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise.”

DEUTERONOMY 6:6-7

DAY 181 · WEEK 26

Deuteronomy 12:1-14:29

Centralized worship; false prophets; clean and unclean foods

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 80 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 12:1-14:29. These chapters begin the long section of specific laws. They deal with worship in one place, warnings about false prophets, and rules about food and tithes. Read them with attention to why God gives each one.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

From chapter 12 to chapter 26, Moses applies the Ten Commandments to the life of Israel in the land. The first group of laws is about worship. Israel is to worship only in the place God chooses, to destroy the altars of the nations, and to resist the temptation to follow other gods, even when it comes from a prophet or a family member. Chapter 14 returns to the clean and unclean foods and the tithe.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "You shall surely destroy all the places where the nations whom you shall dispossess served their gods" (12:2).
2. "You shall seek the place that the LORD your God will choose out of all your tribes... and there you shall go" (12:5).
3. "You shall rejoice before the LORD your God, you and your sons and your daughters" (12:12).
4. A prophet who tells Israel to follow other gods is to be rejected, "for the LORD your God is testing you" (13:1-3).
5. Even a brother, a son, or a close friend who entices to idolatry must not be heeded (13:6-11).

6. “You are the sons of the LORD your God” (14:1).
7. The clean and unclean animals are listed again (14:3-21), with the reason, “For you are a people holy to the LORD your God” (14:2, 21).
8. The tithe is to be eaten before the LORD with rejoicing, and every third year given to the Levite, the sojourner, the fatherless, and the widow (14:22-29).

STEP 4

Interpretation

These chapters are about protecting the purity of worship. The command to centralize worship at one place might seem merely administrative, but it has a theological purpose. Dozens of local altars would invite syncretism, mixing the worship of the LORD with the practices of Canaan. One place, chosen by God, keeps the worship unified and under his direction.

The repeated call to rejoice is easy to miss. Worship is to be a feast. The people are told to eat and rejoice in God’s presence, with their families, their servants, and the Levites. This is a faith of celebration. The tithe is not only a tax. It is a meal, a feast shared with the poor and the stranger. Every third year, the tithe is stored locally to care for the vulnerable.

Chapter 13 contains a hard word. Even a prophet who performs signs is to be rejected if he leads people to other gods. The test is not power but doctrine. And God says that such a prophet is a test, “to know whether you love the LORD your God with all your heart.” Love for God is shown by loyalty to his word, even when someone with an impressive sign says otherwise. This applies to those closest to us as well: love for God must not be overridden by family ties.

The beginning of chapter 14 gives the reason for the food laws: “You are the sons of the LORD your God.” They are not arbitrary rules. They are marks of identity. The distinctive diet was a daily reminder that Israel was God’s family.

These chapters show that holiness is expressed in how we worship, whom we follow, what we eat, and how we care for the poor. It is a whole life. And at its center is gladness, not grim duty.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus told the woman at the well that “the hour is coming, and is now here, when the true worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and truth” (John 4:23). The warning about false prophets is repeated by Jesus (Matthew 7:15) and by John (1 John 4:1). Peter was shown that

no food is unclean (Acts 10:15), and Paul said that the kingdom of God is “righteousness and peace and joy in the Holy Spirit” (Romans 14:17). Hebrews 12:22-24 describes the joyful assembly of the church.

STEP 6

Application

Think about whether your worship has joy in it. Plan one way to celebrate God’s goodness with others this week.

Test the voices you listen to by Scripture. Ask whether any are leading you away from Christ.

Give generously, and include someone in need.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from loving anything more than him.
- Thank him that you are his son or daughter.
- Ask him to make you generous to the poor.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 26

“And these words that I command you today shall be on your heart. You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise.”

DEUTERONOMY 6:6-7

DAY 182 · WEEK 26

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Deuteronomy 6:6-7 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And these words that I command you today shall be on your heart. You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise."

DEUTERONOMY 6:6-7

REST

Meditation

These two verses follow the Shema and describe how love for God is meant to be lived out. They are among the most practical verses in the Bible.

"These words that I command you today shall be on your heart." The order matters. Before anything is taught to anyone else, the words must be on your own heart. A parent, teacher, or leader cannot pass on what he does not possess. The heart is the starting point.

"You shall teach them diligently to your children." The word "diligently" means to sharpen, as one sharpens a blade. It suggests repetition and care. Faith is not passed on by accident. It requires intention and effort. Notice that the commandment is addressed to parents. God's design is for faith to be taught at home first.

“And shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise.” This is the surprising part. The teaching is not limited to a scheduled lesson. It is woven into the whole day: sitting, walking, going to bed, getting up. Every part of life becomes a moment to speak of God.

For the Christian, the verses call us to make Scripture and prayer part of our household. It is a ministry for parents, but also for grandparents, aunts, uncles, church members, and friends. In Christ, the whole community of believers shares the task of passing on the faith to the next generation.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the opening sermons of Deuteronomy. You saw how Moses looked back at the wilderness, how he restated the Ten Commandments, and how he gave the Shema, the greatest commandment. You read about God’s choice of Israel, not because of their righteousness, and about Moses’ intercession after the golden calf. You prayed through Psalm 78, which tells the whole story from the exodus to David as a lesson for the next generation. You read the first laws about worship, false prophets, clean foods, and the tithe. The week taught that obedience flows from love, that faith must be passed on at home, and that God’s grace is not based on our merit.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The Shema says that God is one and calls for love with heart, soul, and might. Which of these three, heart, soul, or might, is the hardest for you to give, and why?

Moses told Israel three times that God’s gift was “not because of your righteousness.” How does Christ’s work on your behalf give you the same assurance?

Deuteronomy 6 says to teach faith “when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way.” What is one practical step you could take this week to talk about God in the course of ordinary life?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to put his words on your heart and help you teach them to those near you.

Thank him that his love is not based on your merit.

Rest in him today.

DAY 183 · WEEK 27

Deuteronomy 15:1-16:22

Sabbath year; the feasts of remembrance

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 51 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 15:1-16:22. These chapters deal with the release of debts, the care of the poor, the freeing of slaves, and the three great pilgrim feasts. Notice how generosity is rooted in remembering.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Moses continues applying the law to life in the land. Chapter 15 describes the Sabbath year, in which debts are released every seventh year, and the freeing of Hebrew slaves. Chapter 16 sets out the three annual feasts: Passover, Weeks, and Booths. These laws shape a community in which no one is permanently poor and every family rejoices together.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "At the end of every seven years you shall grant a release" (15:1).
2. "But there will be no poor among you… if only you will strictly obey the voice of the LORD" (15:4-5).
3. "If among you, one of your brothers should become poor… you shall not harden your heart or shut your hand against your poor brother" (15:7).
4. "You shall open your hand to your brother, to the needy and to the poor, in your land" (15:11).
5. "For there will never cease to be poor in the land" (15:11).
6. Hebrew slaves are to be freed in the seventh year and sent out with gifts: "You shall not let him go empty-handed" (15:12-15).

7. “You shall remember that you were a slave in the land of Egypt, and the LORD your God redeemed you” (15:15).

8. The three feasts are Passover, Weeks, and Booths, and “they shall not appear before the LORD empty-handed” (16:16-17). Judges are to “follow justice, and only justice” (16:18-20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The laws in chapter 15 are among the most radical in the Bible. Every seven years, debts are cancelled. The point is to prevent a permanent underclass. In most societies, debt becomes a trap that passes from generation to generation. God’s law builds in a periodic reset.

There is a tension in the passage that is worth noticing. Verse 4 says that there will be no poor among you if you obey. Verse 11 says that the poor will never cease from the land. Both are true. The first is the goal of the law, a society so generous that poverty cannot take root. The second is the realistic observation that because of sin, the ideal will not be fully reached. The command that follows is to open your hand anyway.

The sentence that gives the law its power is 15:15: “You shall remember that you were a slave in the land of Egypt, and the LORD your God redeemed you.” Generosity is rooted in memory. The reason the Israelite should free a slave is that he was freed. The reason he gives is that he was given to. The gospel always works this way: we love because he first loved us.

The detail about sending a freed slave away with gifts shows the spirit of the law. He is not just released; he is given a start. “You shall furnish him liberally from your flock, your threshing floor, and your winepress.” Grace is not stingy.

Chapter 16 sets out the pilgrim feasts as occasions of joy. Everyone is to take part: sons, daughters, servants, Levites, strangers, orphans, and widows. And the instruction to judges to pursue justice, and only justice, completes the picture of a society in which God’s character is reflected.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus announced the “year of the LORD’s favor” (Luke 4:19) and taught, “Give to everyone who begs from you” (Luke 6:30). He said, “For you always have the poor with you” (Matthew 26:11), referring to Deuteronomy 15:11. Paul says, “You know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though he was rich, yet for your sake he became poor” (2 Corinthians 8:9). The church in Acts shared its goods so that “there was not a needy person among them” (Acts 4:34).

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether your hand is open or closed toward someone in need. Make a concrete gift this week.

Forgive a debt or a wrong that someone owes you.

Remember your own redemption, and let it shape how you treat others.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for redeeming you and being generous beyond measure.

Ask him to open your hand to someone in need.

Ask him to teach you to forgive as you have been forgiven.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 27

"The LORD your God will raise up for you a prophet like me from among you, from your brothers; it is to him you shall listen."

DEUTERONOMY 18:15

DAY 184 · WEEK 27

Deuteronomy 18:15-19; Psalm 110; Hebrews 1:1-4

The Three Offices of Christ, Prophet, Priest, King

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 18:15-19, Psalm 110, and Hebrews 1:1-4. Take your time with these three short passages. They each speak of one of the three offices that God established in Israel, prophet, priest, and king, and the way that all three come together in Jesus.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Today's reading pauses in the middle of the laws of Deuteronomy, just before the chapter that sets out the roles of kings, priests, and prophets in Israel (Deuteronomy 17 and 18). It pauses to ask a question that will come up many times in the story ahead: how do the offices of Israel point to Christ? The three passages you read today are central. Moses promises a prophet like himself, David writes of a king who is also a priest forever, and the writer of Hebrews says that in Jesus, God has spoken his final word.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD your God will raise up for you a prophet like me from among you, from your brothers; it is to him you shall listen" (Deuteronomy 18:15).
2. "I will put my words in his mouth, and he shall speak to them all that I command him" (Deuteronomy 18:18).
3. "The LORD says to my Lord: Sit at my right hand, until I make your enemies your footstool" (Psalm 110:1).
4. "The LORD has sworn and will not change his mind: You are a priest forever after the order of Melchizedek" (Psalm 110:4).

5. “He will execute judgment among the nations, filling them with corpses” (Psalm 110:6).
6. “Long ago, at many times and in many ways, God spoke to our fathers by the prophets, but in these last days he has spoken to us by his Son” (Hebrews 1:1-2).
7. “He is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature, and he upholds the universe by the word of his power” (Hebrews 1:3).
8. “After making purification for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high” (Hebrews 1:3).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The three offices of Christ is a way of organizing what the Bible teaches about who Jesus is and what he does. It was developed by John Calvin and has been used by Reformed and many other Christian traditions ever since. It rests on a simple observation: in the Old Testament, three kinds of people were anointed to serve God’s people, the prophet, the priest, and the king. Each represents a way in which God relates to his people. Each was incomplete. And all three find their fulfillment in the one called Messiah, which means “Anointed One.”

Consider the prophet first. A prophet speaks for God to the people. Moses was the model prophet, to whom God spoke “mouth to mouth” (Numbers 12:8). In Deuteronomy 18, Moses promises that God would one day raise up another like him. Over the centuries, many prophets came, but the people kept waiting for the prophet. Jesus is that prophet, and more. The Gospel of John says, “No one has ever seen God; the only God, who is at the Father’s side, he has made him known” (John 1:18). Where prophets spoke the word of God, Jesus is the Word of God. Hebrews 1 says that God has now spoken by his Son. As prophet, Christ reveals the Father to us and teaches us the truth. He does this through his own teaching, through the Spirit who inspired the Scriptures, and through the Spirit who illumines our hearts.

Consider the priest next. A priest speaks to God on behalf of the people. He offers sacrifices, makes intercession, and blesses. The priests of Israel, from Aaron onward, did this imperfectly. They were sinners, and they died, so that new priests were always needed. Psalm 110:4 announces a priest of another kind, “after the order of Melchizedek,” a priest forever. Hebrews develops this at length. Jesus is the great high priest who has offered, once for all, the perfect sacrifice, namely himself (Hebrews 7:27). He continually intercedes for us at the right hand of God (Romans 8:34; Hebrews 7:25). As priest, Christ reconciles us to God by his death and keeps us in fellowship with him by his prayers.

Consider the king last. A king rules the people on behalf of God. David was the model king, and God promised him a son who would reign forever (2 Samuel 7). Psalm 110:1 says that David's Lord sits at God's right hand until his enemies are made a footstool. Jesus applied this psalm to himself (Matthew 22:41-45). He is the king who has been raised and exalted, who rules now over his church and the universe, and who will return to judge and to bring all things under his feet. As king, Christ governs us by his word and Spirit, defends us from our enemies, and will finally subdue all things.

Why do the three offices matter? Because they correct our one-sided views of Jesus. Some think of him only as a teacher, a moral guide who gave us a better way to live. That is the prophet without the priest or king. Others think of him only as a Savior who forgives sins, but they do not think of him as one who governs their lives. That is the priest without the king. Others think of him mostly as a ruler, but forget that he came to die. The full Jesus is prophet, priest, and king.

The three offices also show what it means to be a Christian. We are united to Christ, and so we share in his offices. Believers are taught by his word, so we listen as prophets who speak the truth. We are priests who offer spiritual sacrifices (1 Peter 2:5, 9). And we are kings who will reign with him, as we learn to rule our own hearts and serve others (Revelation 1:6; 5:10). The offices are not only a way to understand Jesus. They are a way to understand our calling in him.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The three passages you read today are linked by a single idea: God's final word to his people comes through a person, and that person holds the highest offices in Israel.

Start with Deuteronomy 18. Moses speaks to a people who are afraid of hearing God's voice directly. At Horeb they said, "Let me not hear again the voice of the LORD my God." God answered that he would send a prophet like Moses, one who would speak all that God commanded. The people are told, "It is to him you shall listen." Notice what is required: listening. The whole law of Moses was incomplete, and it pointed forward to a prophet who would complete it. The next verses of the chapter add a stern warning that anyone who does not listen to that prophet will answer for it.

Psalm 110 is the most quoted psalm in the New Testament. In it, David speaks of a figure he calls "my Lord," someone greater than David himself. This person sits at God's right hand, which is the place of supreme honor. He is a king, who rules in the midst of his enemies, and he is a priest forever. In Israel, the two roles were kept separate, and kings who tried to act as

priests were judged (2 Chronicles 26:16-21). Yet here is one who holds both, and he is established not by descent but by the oath of God. The psalm asks the reader to think about who this could be.

Hebrews 1 gives the answer. The author opens his letter by contrasting the many partial words of the prophets with the one final Word of the Son. Then he describes the Son in three ways: heir of all things and creator of the world (a kingly role), the radiance of God's glory (a prophetic role, as the one who reveals God), and the one who made purification for sins (a priestly role). Then he says that the Son "sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high," echoing Psalm 110:1. All three offices come together in a single verse.

Taken together, the passages give a picture of fullness. God spoke in the past in pieces. Now he has spoken in a person. The Son is not just one more messenger. He is the message.

STEP 5

Connection

The New Testament repeatedly applies these three offices to Jesus. The crowds said, "This is indeed the Prophet who is to come into the world" (John 6:14). Peter preached that Jesus is the prophet like Moses (Acts 3:22-23), and Stephen did the same (Acts 7:37). Jesus claimed Psalm 110 for himself in front of the Sanhedrin (Mark 14:62). Hebrews 4:14-5:10 and 7:1-28 expound his priesthood. Revelation 19:16 calls him "King of kings and Lord of lords."

STEP 6

Application

Listen to Jesus as your prophet. Choose a passage in the Gospels today and ask what he is saying to you.

Draw near to him as your priest. Bring a specific need or sin to him in prayer, trusting that he intercedes for you.

Submit to him as your king. Ask whether there is any area of your life that you have not yet put under his rule.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus as your prophet, priest, and king, and tell him which of these you most need today.

Ask him to speak, and listen.

Ask him to rule you and help you obey.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 27

"The LORD your God will raise up for you a prophet like me from among you, from your brothers; it is to him you shall listen."

DEUTERONOMY 18:15

DAY 185 · WEEK 27

Deuteronomy 17:1-18:22

Kings, priests, prophets, the offices typology

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 42 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 17:1-18:22. Having paused to see where the offices lead, return now to the text itself. This reading describes how judges, kings, priests, and prophets are to function in Israel. Look especially at the instructions for the king.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Moses sets out how Israel's offices are to work. Chapter 17 covers the administration of justice and, remarkably, a law for kings, though Israel has no king yet. Chapter 18 covers the Levitical priests and the prophets. Together they describe how God intended to govern his people under his law, with every office limited by the word of God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. A person accused of idolatry is to be convicted on "the evidence of two witnesses or of three witnesses" (17:2-7).
2. Hard cases are to be taken to the Levitical priests and the judge at the place the LORD chooses (17:8-13).
3. "When you come to the land… and you say, I will set a king over me, like all the nations that are around me, you may indeed set a king over you whom the LORD your God will choose" (17:14-15).
4. The king "must not acquire many horses for himself… neither shall he acquire many wives for himself… nor shall he acquire for himself excessive silver and gold" (17:16-17).
5. He is to write for himself a copy of the law and "read in it all the days of his life" (17:18-19).

6. This is so that "his heart may not be lifted up above his brothers" (17:20).
7. The Levites have no inheritance among their brothers: "The LORD is his inheritance" (18:1-8).
8. Israel is forbidden to practice divination, sorcery, or spiritism. The LORD will raise up a prophet like Moses, and false prophets are to be tested by whether their words come to pass (18:9-22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The law of the king is one of the most remarkable passages in the Old Testament. Written centuries before Israel's first king, it limits his power in advance. The king is to be chosen by God, he is to be one of the people, he must not accumulate horses, wives, or wealth, and he must read the law every day. The only checks on ancient kings were usually other kings. Here the check is the word of God.

Look at the three prohibitions. Horses represent military power, and especially a return to Egypt, the source of horses. Wives represent political alliances, and also divided loyalties. Silver and gold represent wealth and the temptation to trust in it. Each is a way of relying on something other than God. Solomon, the wisest of kings, violated all three, and his story shows what happens when the instructions are ignored.

The king's key duty is positive: he must write out a copy of the law with his own hand, keep it with him, and read it all his life. The result is humility, so that "his heart may not be lifted up above his brothers." A king who knows the law knows that he is under it. The best leaders are those who submit to a higher authority.

The prophet is the last office. Moses promises that God will raise up a prophet like him. In the immediate sense, this is a promise of a line of prophets who will speak for God. But the singular, "a prophet like me," and the later note in Deuteronomy 34:10 that no prophet had yet risen like Moses, led Israel to look for one greater prophet. The test of a true prophet is simple: his words must be God's words, and they must prove true.

The Levites' situation is described again: no inheritance, because the LORD is their inheritance. Those who serve at God's altar share in the offerings. They live by faith.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the king who does not seek his own glory, who humbled himself and became obedient to death (Philippians 2:6-8). He is the king who knew the law perfectly and answered temptation with the words of Deuteronomy. He is the prophet like Moses, and

Peter says so in Acts 3:22. He is also the one who calls false prophets to account (Matthew 7:15-20), and who is himself the standard by which they are measured (1 John 4:1-3).

STEP 6

Application

If you have any role of authority, read the law of the king as a mirror. Where are you tempted toward power, status, or wealth?

Commit to a daily reading of Scripture, as the king was to do.

Test what you hear from teachers against the word of God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to keep you from the pride of power.

Ask him to make you a daily reader of his word.

Thank Jesus, the true king and prophet who humbled himself for you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 27

"The LORD your God will raise up for you a prophet like me from among you, from your brothers; it is to him you shall listen."

DEUTERONOMY 18:15

DAY 186 · WEEK 27

Deuteronomy 19:1-21:23

Cities of refuge; warfare; difficult cases

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 76 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 19:1-21:23. These chapters deal with cities of refuge, witnesses, warfare, and a series of difficult cases. Read them slowly. Some are hard, and they should be understood in the context of ancient Israel as a nation under the old covenant.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Moses continues applying the law to civil life. He repeats the provision for cities of refuge, stresses the need for honest witnesses, sets out rules for warfare, and addresses a series of specific situations: an unsolved murder, a captive woman, the rights of the firstborn, a rebellious son, and the body of an executed criminal. These cases show how the law dealt with the real complications of community life.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Three cities of refuge are to be set apart, with roads prepared and room for three more if the territory expands (19:1-10).
2. “A single witness shall not suffice… only on the evidence of two witnesses or of three witnesses shall a charge be established” (19:15).
3. A false witness is to receive the punishment that he intended for the accused (19:16-21).
4. Before battle, the priest is to say, “Hear, O Israel, today you are drawing near for battle against your enemies: let not your heart faint. Do not fear” (20:1-4).
5. Those who are afraid, newly married, or have just built a house are excused from battle (20:5-9).

6. When a corpse is found in the field, the elders of the nearest city must wash their hands and say, “Our hands did not shed this blood” (21:1-9).
7. Firstborn sons have a right to a double portion, even if their father prefers another wife’s son (21:15-17).
8. “A hanged man is cursed by God,” and his body must not remain overnight on the tree (21:22-23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

These chapters show that Israel’s law was not a code of rigid rules but a system for taking human life, truth, and community seriously. The cities of refuge protect the innocent. The rule of two or three witnesses protects the accused. The penalty for false witnesses, to receive what they meant for others, is a strict deterrent. Together, they show a concern for justice that was remarkable in the ancient world.

Notice the tenderness of the rules of war. A priest tells the soldiers not to be afraid, because “the LORD your God is he who goes with you.” Men who have just married or built a house are sent home, so that they do not die before enjoying what they have started. Even the fearful are released, so that their fear does not spread. This is not the rhetoric of a war machine. It is a view of war as a grave and limited matter.

The case of the unsolved murder is a striking picture of communal responsibility. When someone is found dead and no one knows who killed him, the nearest town is responsible for making atonement. The elders wash their hands over a heifer whose neck is broken, and pray, “Forgive, O LORD, your people Israel.” It shows that bloodshed pollutes a community, and that someone must acknowledge it.

The rule about the firstborn protects a son from the favoritism of a father. Even the unloved wife’s son has his rights. God’s law is concerned with fairness inside the family.

The last verse, 21:23, is the most important for what comes later. A body hanged on a tree was cursed, and it was to be buried by sundown, so that the land would not be defiled. The person was cursed “by God.” It was a mark of the deepest shame. The New Testament sees this as a description of what Christ would bear.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes Deuteronomy 21:23 in Galatians 3:13: “Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us.” Peter says that Jesus “bore our sins in his body on the tree” (1 Peter 2:24). The requirement of two or three witnesses is quoted by Jesus (Matthew 18:16)

and Paul (2 Corinthians 13:1). The cities of refuge point to Christ as our refuge (Hebrews 6:18). Jesus told his disciples, “Do not be afraid,” as he sent them out.

STEP 6

Application

Think about how you treat people in disputes. Are you fair and honest in what you say about them?

Read Galatians 3:13 and thank Christ for taking the curse in your place.

If there is fear in your heart, hear the priest’s words from 20:4: “The LORD your God is he who goes with you.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for becoming a curse for you on the tree.
- Ask God to make you honest and fair in your dealings.
- Ask him to go with you into the battles you face.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 27

“The LORD your God will raise up for you a prophet like me from among you, from your brothers; it is to him you shall listen.”

DEUTERONOMY 18:15

DAY 187 · WEEK 27

Deuteronomy 22:1-25:19

Social and moral laws, justice in covenant community

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 92 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 22:1-25:19. This is the longest section of specific laws. It covers everyday matters of community life, from lost animals to marriage, to honest weights. Read it as a picture of how God cares about the details of ordinary life.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These chapters read like a collection of case laws. They touch on how to treat a neighbor's property, sexual morality, who may belong to the assembly of the LORD, hygiene in the camp, treatment of the poor and the foreigner, marriage and divorce, and business ethics. Some of the laws are hard to understand, as they come from a very different time and culture. But the principles behind them are clear.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "You shall not see your brother's ox or his sheep going astray, and hide yourselves from them. You shall take them back to your brother" (22:1).
2. "You shall make a parapet for your roof, that you may not bring the guilt of blood upon your house" (22:8).
3. "You shall not plow with an ox and a donkey together" (22:10).
4. A man who is newly married is to be free from military service for a year, "to be happy with his wife" (24:5).
5. "You shall not oppress a hired servant who is poor and needy" (24:14-15).
6. "Fathers shall not be put to death because of their children, nor shall children be put to death because of their fathers" (24:16).

7. “When you reap your harvest in your field and forget a sheaf… it shall be for the sojourner, the fatherless, and the widow” (24:19).

8. “You shall have a full and just weight, a full and just measure” (25:13-16). “You shall blot out the memory of Amalek” (25:17-19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The laws of these chapters show the extent of God’s concern. He cares about a lost ox, a house roof, a pair of unlike animals, the wages of a day laborer, the way a person lends, and how fair a merchant’s scale is. Nothing is too small. This is a God who is holy in the market as well as in the temple.

The first law sets the tone: if you see your neighbor’s animal wandering, you must take it back. You cannot say, “It’s not my problem.” To love your neighbor means taking active responsibility for his welfare. The same principle shows up in the roof parapet. Because roofs were used as living space, a house owner has to make them safe. If you build a house, you take responsibility for the safety of anyone who enters it.

Several laws protect the vulnerable. The hired servant must be paid on the same day, because he is poor and depends on the wages. The gleaning laws leave behind some of the harvest for the poor. A creditor may not enter a debtor’s home to take a pledge, nor keep his cloak overnight. Foreigners, widows, and orphans are not to be denied justice. Each of these says, “Remember that you were a slave in Egypt.” Generosity is grounded in redemption.

A line in 24:16 is a landmark: each person is responsible for his own sin. In a world where families were often punished together, this was a significant principle. It shows that God’s justice is personal.

The call for honest weights and measures says that business ethics is a matter of worship. “For all who do such things, all who act dishonestly, are an abomination to the LORD your God.” The God of Israel cares what your scale says.

The section ends with a reminder of Amalek, the nation that attacked the weak and tired at the rear of Israel’s column when they came out of Egypt. This is the theme again: God is the defender of the weak.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said that the second great commandment is to love your neighbor as yourself, and in the parable of the Good Samaritan he extended “neighbor” to anyone in need (Luke 10:25-37). Paul quotes the law about the ox, “You shall not muzzle an ox when it treads out the grain,” to

support paying those who preach (1 Corinthians 9:9). James 5:4 echoes the law about unpaid wages. Jesus' compassion for the weak, the hungry, and the foreigner is the fulfillment of these laws.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether there is a "lost ox" in your life, something of a neighbor's that you could help return.

Review your business and financial dealings. Are your weights and measures honest?

Think about how you treat workers, and whether there is someone you should pay or tip more fairly.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to make you honest, fair, and generous in practical ways.
- Tell him one way you want to love a neighbor this week.
- Thank Jesus for his compassion.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 27

"The LORD your God will raise up for you a prophet like me from among you, from your brothers; it is to him you shall listen."

DEUTERONOMY 18:15

DAY 188 · WEEK 27

Deuteronomy 26:1-28:14

Firstfruits; the blessings of obedience

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 49 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 26:1-28:14. This reading covers the firstfruits offering, a covenant ceremony at Ebal and Gerizim, and the first part of the great blessings and curses. Read the confession in 26:5-10 aloud as a creed.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The long section of laws comes to an end with a ritual and a ceremony. In chapter 26, Moses describes the firstfruits offering that Israelites are to bring when they enter the land, including a short statement of faith to be recited. In chapter 27, he commands the people to set up large stones when they cross the Jordan and to pronounce blessings and curses at Mount Gerizim and Mount Ebal. Chapter 28 begins the blessings and curses themselves, and you read the blessings first.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The Israelite is to bring the firstfruits to the place that the LORD chooses and say, “A wandering Aramean was my father” (26:1-5).
2. The creed tells the story: Egypt, affliction, the cry to the LORD, the exodus, the land, and the firstfruits (26:5-10).
3. “And you shall rejoice in all the good that the LORD your God has given to you” (26:11).
4. This day the LORD your God commands you to do these statutes… “You have declared today that the LORD is your God… and the LORD has declared today that you are a people for his treasured possession” (26:16-19).
5. The people are to set up stones on Mount Ebal, plaster them, and write on them all the words of the law (27:1-8).

6. Six tribes are to stand on Gerizim for the blessing and six on Ebal for the curse (27:11-14).
7. The Levites are to recite curses, and all the people say "Amen" (27:15-26).
8. "And all these blessings shall come upon you and overtake you, if you obey the voice of the LORD your God" (28:2). "The LORD will make you the head and not the tail" (28:13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The confession in chapter 26 is a brilliant piece of teaching. It tells the whole story of salvation in a few sentences. "A wandering Aramean was my father." It starts with the humility of Jacob. Then it recalls the slavery, the cry, the rescue, and the gift of the land. And then the worshiper says, "Behold, now I bring the firstfruits of the ground that you, O LORD, have given me." The offering is a response to the story.

This is how all Christian giving should work. We are not buying God's favor. We are returning a portion of what he has given because of what he has done. Worship rests on remembering.

The ceremony at Ebal and Gerizim is a dramatic act of covenant renewal. The people are divided on two mountains, with the Levites and the ark in the valley between. Curses are read from one side, blessings from the other. The curses listed in chapter 27 deal with secret sins: idolatry, dishonoring parents, moving boundary markers, taking bribes. After each one, the people say "Amen." They are agreeing to the consequences. It is a vivid way of saying that no one can say later that he did not know.

The blessings in chapter 28 are expansive. Blessing in the city and in the field, in the womb and the harvest, in coming in and going out. The pattern is of a life under God's favor that touches everything. Verse 13 says, "The LORD will make you the head and not the tail." Yet it is conditional: "if you obey." Everything depends on the heart's response.

It is important to read this in light of the whole book. Moses has said that Israel was stubborn and that the land was a gift of grace. The blessings are not wages. They are what happens in a life lived within God's goodness. The tragedy that follows is that Israel does not obey, and the curses fall.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that Christ has redeemed us from the curse of the law, so that in Christ Jesus the blessing of Abraham might come to the Gentiles (Galatians 3:13-14). Ephesians 1:3 says that God "has blessed us in Christ with every spiritual blessing in the heavenly places." The Amen

of the people finds its echo in 2 Corinthians 1:20, where all the promises of God find their "Yes" in Christ, and "through him is our Amen." Revelation 5:14 shows the living creatures saying "Amen."

STEP 6

Application

Write out your own short account of God's work in your life, in the pattern of 26:5-10. Say it aloud as a prayer.

Make an offering of thanks, as a response and not as a payment.

Think about the "secret sins" of chapter 27. Is there one that you need to bring into the light?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Bring God a portion of what he has given you, and tell him what that is.
- Thank him for blessing you in Christ with every spiritual blessing.
- Ask him to let your "Amen" be true.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 27

"The LORD your God will raise up for you a prophet like me from among you, from your brothers; it is to him you shall listen."

DEUTERONOMY 18:15

DAY 189 · WEEK 27

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Deuteronomy 18:15 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The LORD your God will raise up for you a prophet like me from among you, from your brothers; it is to him you shall listen."

DEUTERONOMY 18:15

REST

Meditation

Deuteronomy 18:15 is a promise and a command in a single sentence. It was spoken by Moses near the end of his life, and it is quoted in the New Testament as a promise fulfilled in Jesus.

"The LORD your God will raise up for you." The prophet is a gift from God. He is not self-appointed. God takes the initiative to speak to his people, and he does it by raising up someone for them. The whole idea of revelation begins with God.

"A prophet like me." Moses was the greatest prophet of the Old Testament. God spoke with him face to face. He mediated the covenant, performed signs, led the people out of Egypt, and gave the law. To be "like Moses" is a high standard. Deuteronomy 34:10 says that no prophet had yet arisen like him. The promise looks beyond the line of ordinary prophets to someone who would be like Moses, and greater.

“From among you, from your brothers.” The prophet will be one of them. He is a true human being, a member of the covenant family. This points to the incarnation, in which God’s Son became a man.

“It is to him you shall listen.” The command is simple: listen. The Father said the same thing at the transfiguration, when Moses and Elijah appeared with Jesus: “This is my beloved Son; listen to him” (Mark 9:7). The prophet like Moses has come, and he is the Son.

To be a Christian is to be a listener of Jesus. Spend today in quiet listening. Read the Gospels slowly, and ask him to speak.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read more of Moses’ sermons in Deuteronomy. You saw that the Lord’s election of Israel was not based on their righteousness, and you read of the golden calf and Moses’ intercession again. You prayed through the second half of Psalm 78, which ends with the choice of David as shepherd. You read laws about worship, false prophets, the tithe, the release of debts, and the care of the poor, and you studied the three offices of Christ as prophet, priest, and king. You read the law of the king and the promise of a prophet like Moses, and a long series of laws about justice, warfare, and daily life. You read the firstfruits creed, the covenant ceremony at Ebal and Gerizim, and the first blessings of obedience. The week taught that God’s law shapes every part of life, and that all of Israel’s offices find their fulfillment in Christ.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Moses promised a prophet like himself, and Jesus is that prophet. What is the difference between knowing about Jesus and listening to him?

The three offices of prophet, priest, and king show different sides of Christ’s work. Which of the three do you most need to lean on at this stage of your life, and why?

The firstfruits creed ends with rejoicing in “all the good that the LORD your God has given.” What good things has God given you that you have not stopped to thank him for?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus as your prophet, priest, and king.

Ask him to speak today and to help you listen.

Rest in him this Sabbath.

DAY 190 · WEEK 28

Psalm 119:1-48

The word of God as lamp, loving Scripture

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Psalm · 48 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 119:1-48. This is the longest psalm and the longest chapter in the Bible, and it is a prayer in praise of God's word. You will read it in four sections over the next week. Today, read slowly, perhaps a few stanzas at a time, and notice the many words for God's word.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 119 is an acrostic. It has twenty-two sections of eight verses each, one for each letter of the Hebrew alphabet, and in each section every verse begins with that letter. The author is not named, though the psalmist speaks as a young man who has faced mockery and affliction. Nearly every verse uses one of eight or so words for God's revealed will: law, testimonies, precepts, statutes, commandments, rules, word, and promise. It follows Deuteronomy in the plan because the whole book of Deuteronomy is a sermon on loving and keeping God's word.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Blessed are those whose way is blameless, who walk in the law of the LORD!" (v. 1).
2. "How can a young man keep his way pure? By guarding it according to your word" (v. 9).
3. "I have stored up your word in my heart, that I might not sin against you" (v. 11).
4. "Open my eyes, that I may behold wondrous things out of your law" (v. 18).
5. "I am a sojourner on the earth; hide not your commandments from me!" (v. 19).
6. "My soul clings to the dust; give me life according to your word!" (v. 25).
7. "I will run in the way of your commandments when you enlarge my heart!" (v. 32).

8 “Turn my eyes from looking at worthless things; and give me life in your ways” (v. 37). “And I shall walk in a wide place, for I have sought your precepts” (v. 45).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with blessing, and the word is the first word of the Psalter too (Psalm 1:1). The blessed are those who walk in the law of the LORD. This is not a grim path. It is the way of life. The psalmist loves God’s word, and he says so again and again. For him, the law is not an external burden. It is a delight.

Notice the psalmist’s honesty about his need. “My soul clings to the dust.” “Open my eyes.” “Enlarge my heart.” He cannot keep the word by his own strength. He asks God to help him understand it, to love it, and to keep it. The psalm is full of prayer. Reading the Bible is not an exercise in willpower. It is a conversation with God, who must give understanding and desire.

The verse about the young man is among the best-known. How can he keep his way pure? By living according to God’s word. The method is stated in verse 11: “I have stored up your word in my heart.” Memorization and meditation are the way that Scripture shapes behavior. We guard our way by filling our hearts with God’s word, so that when temptation comes, it is already there.

The psalmist also faces opposition. Proud people mock him and princes sit and plot against him. Yet he says that he will speak of God’s testimonies before kings and not be put to shame. His confidence is not in his own reputation, but in the promise. Faith in the word gives courage to speak.

The first section ends with a prayer for freedom: “I shall walk in a wide place.” The world sees obedience as narrow. The psalmist sees it as wide. God’s commands do not confine him. They take him out of the narrow place of sin and into spaciousness.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Blessed rather are those who hear the word of God and keep it” (Luke 11:28), and “If you abide in my word, you are truly my disciples” (John 8:31). He answered temptation with the word of God. Paul says that all Scripture is breathed out by God (2 Timothy 3:16). The psalmist’s prayer to open his eyes is answered when Jesus “opened their minds to understand the Scriptures” (Luke 24:45).

STEP 6

Application

Pick one verse from today's reading to store in your heart, and write it on a card.

Pray verse 18 before you open your Bible: "Open my eyes, that I may behold wondrous things."

Ask whether you see God's commands as narrow or wide.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you want to walk in his word and love it.
- Ask him to open your eyes to wonderful things in it.
- Ask him to store his word in your heart so that you do not sin against him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 28

"The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever, that we may do all the words of this law."

DEUTERONOMY 29:29

DAY 191 · WEEK 28

Psalm 119:49-96

Comfort in affliction; the commandments as songs

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Psalm · 48 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 119:49-96. Today's section moves from joy in the word to comfort in suffering. Notice how the psalmist speaks of affliction.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The second section of the great acrostic psalm continues the theme with a new emphasis. The psalmist is under pressure from the arrogant and wicked, and he turns to God's word for comfort. These verses include some of the most personal confessions in the psalm, as he describes his affliction and his dependence on God's promises.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Remember your word to your servant, in which you have made me hope" (v. 49).
2. "This is my comfort in my affliction, that your promise gives me life" (v. 50).
3. "Your statutes have been my songs in the house of my sojourning" (v. 54).
4. "I have considered my ways and turned my feet to your testimonies; I hasten and do not delay to keep your commandments" (vv. 59-60).
5. "It is good for me that I was afflicted, that I might learn your statutes" (v. 71).
6. "I know, O LORD, that your rules are righteous, and that in faithfulness you have afflicted me" (v. 75).
7. "If your law had not been my delight, I would have perished in my affliction" (v. 92).
8. "I have seen a limit to all perfection, but your commandment is exceedingly broad" (v. 96).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This section is a school of comfort. The psalmist is in distress, but he finds that God's word is a comfort. "This is my comfort in my affliction, that your promise gives me life." The promise is not a vague hope. It is a specific word that God has spoken, and it has the power to give life when everything else seems to be dying.

Verses 54 and 55 are striking. The psalmist calls God's statutes "songs" in the house of his sojourning. A traveler's house might be a poor place, but it is filled with song. The word can turn any dwelling into a place of worship. And at night, he remembers God's name and keeps his law.

The center of the section is verses 67, 71, and 75, where the psalmist reflects on his suffering. "Before I was afflicted I went astray, but now I keep your word." "It is good for me that I was afflicted." It is a hard thing to say, and he does not say it lightly. But he has learned that his troubles were God's way of teaching him. In faithfulness, God has afflicted him. Affliction was not a sign of God's absence. It was a form of his care.

This is not a general claim that all suffering is God's discipline. The psalmist is speaking from his own experience, and he is not claiming to be sinless. But he points to a truth that the whole Bible affirms: God uses hardship to draw us closer to himself. As Hebrews 12:10-11 says, he disciplines us "for our good, that we may share his holiness."

The section ends with a sweeping statement of the word's scope: "I have seen a limit to all perfection, but your commandment is exceedingly broad." Everything else in life has limits. The word of God does not. There is always more to learn, and more to love.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that "suffering produces endurance, and endurance produces character, and character produces hope" (Romans 5:3-4). Hebrews 12:5-11 quotes Proverbs about the Lord's discipline. Jesus is the one who "learned obedience through what he suffered" (Hebrews 5:8). Jesus said, "These things I have spoken to you, that in me you may have peace. In the world you will have tribulation. But take heart; I have overcome the world" (John 16:33).

STEP 6

Application

Think of a hard time that taught you something about God. Thank him for it.

Choose one promise from Scripture to hold on to in a current difficulty.

Sing or hum a psalm as you go about your day, as the psalmist did in the house of his sojourning.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God where you need his promise to give you life.
- Thank him for what he has taught you in affliction.
- Ask him to make his commands your songs.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 28

"The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever, that we may do all the words of this law."

DEUTERONOMY 29:29

DAY 192 · WEEK 28

Deuteronomy 28:15-68

The curses of disobedience, the weight of covenant

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 54 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 28:15-68. This is the longest and most sobering passage in the book. It describes the curses that will fall on Israel if they break the covenant. Read it carefully, and notice what is at the heart of the list.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The blessings of 28:1-14 take only fourteen verses. The curses take fifty-four. Moses is not trying to scare the people but to make sure they understand how serious the covenant is. The curses begin with general disaster and grow to include defeat, siege, famine, disease, and finally exile. The chapter is the most detailed warning in the Old Testament, and the prophets will return to it again and again.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “But if you will not obey the voice of the LORD your God or be careful to do all his commandments… then all these curses shall come upon you” (28:15).
2. “Cursed shall you be in the city, and cursed shall you be in the field” (28:16-19).
3. The LORD will send confusion and frustration in all that you undertake (28:20).
4. The LORD will strike with disease, drought, and defeat before enemies (28:21-26).
5. “You shall be driven mad by the sight that your eyes see” (28:34).
6. A foreign nation will devour the land, and a siege will cause such hunger that people eat their own children (28:49-57).
7. “The LORD will scatter you among all peoples, from one end of the earth to the other” (28:64).

8 “Because you did not serve the LORD your God with joyfulness and gladness of heart, because of the abundance of all things, therefore you shall serve your enemies” (28:47-48).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Read this passage slowly, and do not rush to explain it away. It is meant to be heavy. The curses mirror the blessings, point for point. Where the blessings spoke of rain, harvest, and victory, the curses speak of drought, blight, and defeat. The pattern says that the covenant is real, and that its terms are real. To live apart from God is to lose the goods that he gives.

The turning point is verse 47: “Because you did not serve the LORD your God with joyfulness and gladness of heart, because of the abundance of all things.” The root of the failure is not a dramatic act of rebellion. It is ingratitude. A people who have everything do not thank the giver. The loss of joy in God comes before the loss of everything else.

The curses also include a reversal of the exodus. “The LORD will bring you back in ships to Egypt… and there you shall offer yourselves for sale to your enemies as male and female slaves” (28:68). The people who were rescued from Egypt are sent back into slavery. The covenant that gave them freedom, if broken, takes it away. It is a chilling statement of what covenant unfaithfulness means.

The curses are fulfilled in Israel’s history. The northern kingdom fell to Assyria, and Judah fell to Babylon. The prophets saw the exile as the working out of these very words (see 2 Kings 17 and Daniel 9:11-13). The curses were not idle threats. They happened.

Yet this is not the end of the story. Deuteronomy 30 will promise that, after the curses, God will bring his people back if they return to him. The book of Deuteronomy is balanced between warning and hope, and the warning exists in order to bring people to repentance.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that “all who rely on works of the law are under a curse” (Galatians 3:10), quoting Deuteronomy 27:26, and then that “Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us” (Galatians 3:13). Jesus took the covenant curses on himself at the cross: the darkness, the thirst, the abandonment, and the cry, “My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?” Romans 8:1 says there is no condemnation for those in Christ.

STEP 6

Application

Read the passage as a measure of what Christ endured on your behalf. Thank him.

Ask whether there is a lack of joy and gladness in your service of God. Pray for restoration.

Spend time in gratitude, naming the “abundance” that God has given you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Christ for bearing the curse in your place.
- Confess where you have served God without joy.
- Ask him for a grateful heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 28

“The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever, that we may do all the words of this law.”

DEUTERONOMY 29:29

DAY 193 · WEEK 28

Deuteronomy 29:1-31:29

Covenant renewed; the secret things belong to God

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 79 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 29:1-31:29. In this reading, Moses calls Israel to renew the covenant, gives the famous "secret things" verse, and then hands over leadership to Joshua. Notice the call to choose life.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the blessings and curses, Moses gathers the people for a covenant renewal ceremony in the land of Moab. Chapter 29 describes the covenant, with a warning against secret idolatry and a prophecy of exile. Chapter 30 gives a promise of restoration, a call to choose life, and the statement that God's word is near. Chapter 31 deals with the transfer of leadership to Joshua, the writing of the law, and the foretelling of Israel's future rebellion.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "You have seen all that the LORD did before your eyes in the land of Egypt... But to this day the LORD has not given you a heart to understand or eyes to see or ears to hear" (29:2-4).
2. "It is not with you alone that I am making this sworn covenant, but with whoever is standing here with us today... and with whoever is not here with us today" (29:14-15).
3. "The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever, that we may do all the words of this law" (29:29).
4. "When all these things come upon you... and you return to the LORD your God... then the LORD your God will restore your fortunes and have compassion on you" (30:1-3).
5. "The LORD your God will circumcise your heart and the heart of your offspring, so that you will love the LORD your God with all your heart" (30:6).

6. “For this commandment that I command you today is not too hard for you, neither is it far off” (30:11).

7. “I have set before you life and death, blessing and curse. Therefore choose life, that you and your offspring may live” (30:19).

8. Moses commissions Joshua: “Be strong and courageous… It is the LORD who goes before you. He will be with you; he will not leave you or forsake you” (31:6-8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 29 begins with a startling observation: after all the miracles, Israel still lacks a heart to understand. Moses says that God had not given them “a heart to understand or eyes to see or ears to hear.” It is a surprising admission. Seeing miracles does not change the heart. Only God can do that. And this is exactly what chapter 30 promises: “The LORD your God will circumcise your heart.” The problem of the heart is solved by God’s own gift.

The “secret things” verse is a great statement about knowing and not knowing. There are things God has not told us, and we should not be anxious about them. And there are things he has revealed, which belong to us, so that we may obey. The secret things are God’s business. The revealed things are ours. It frees us from speculation and calls us to obedience.

Chapter 30 is the hope of the book. Even after the curses fall, even after exile, there is a way back. “When you return to the LORD your God… he will gather you.” Repentance is always possible. And the way is not impossible: “The word is very near you. It is in your mouth and in your heart, so that you can do it.” God’s call is not a distant puzzle. It is close at hand.

Then comes the choice. “I have set before you life and death, blessing and curse. Therefore choose life.” Moses puts the whole book into one sentence. The people are not forced. They are invited. And choosing life is described as “loving the LORD your God, obeying his voice, and holding fast to him.”

Chapter 31 turns to the future. Moses commissions Joshua and tells him not to be afraid. He writes the law down and places it beside the ark. And he tells the people that after his death they will become corrupt. The tone is realistic. God knows that they will fail. He gives a song, which you will read tomorrow, to be a witness against them.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes Deuteronomy 30:11-14 in Romans 10:6-8 and applies it to the gospel: “The word is near you, in your mouth and in your heart (that is, the word of faith that we proclaim).” He says that Christ is the end of the law for righteousness to everyone who believes (Romans

10:4). Paul says that circumcision is of the heart (Romans 2:29), and Jesus said, “I came that they may have life and have it abundantly” (John 10:10). Hebrews 13:5 quotes 31:6: “I will never leave you nor forsake you.”

STEP 6

Application

Make a list of “secret things” that trouble you. Give them to God, and act on what is revealed.

Choose life today in one specific decision.

Take courage from God’s promise to Joshua. Receive it as spoken to you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give God the secret things you do not understand.

Ask him to circumcise your heart so that you love him.

Thank him that he goes before you and will not leave you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 28

“The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever, that we may do all the words of this law.”

DEUTERONOMY 29:29

DAY 194 · WEEK 28

Deuteronomy 31:30-32:52

The song of Moses, covenant lawsuit in poetry

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 67 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 31:30-32:52. This is the Song of Moses, a long poem that serves as a witness to Israel. Read it aloud if you can, and notice how it moves from praise to accusation to comfort.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

God has told Moses to write a song and teach it to Israel, so that it will be a witness against them when they turn away. The song is placed after the last of Moses' sermons. It is a poem in the form of a covenant lawsuit: it summons heaven and earth as witnesses, states God's faithfulness, charges Israel with unfaithfulness, announces judgment, and ends with a promise of vindication. After the song, God tells Moses to go up Mount Nebo and die.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Give ear, O heavens, and I will speak, and let the earth hear the words of my mouth" (32:1).
2. "The Rock, his work is perfect, for all his ways are justice. A God of faithfulness and without iniquity, just and upright is he" (32:4).
3. "They have dealt corruptly with him; they are no longer his children because they are blemished" (32:5).
4. "Is not he your father, who created you, who made you and established you?" (32:6).
5. "The LORD's portion is his people, Jacob his allotted heritage" (32:9). He found him in a desert land… "he encircled him, he cared for him, he kept him as the apple of his eye" (32:10).

6. “Like an eagle that stirs up its nest, that flutters over its young, spreading out its wings, catching them, bearing them on its pinions” (32:11).
7. “But Jeshurun grew fat, and kicked… He forsook God who made him and scoffed at the Rock of his salvation” (32:15).
8. “See now that I, even I, am he, and there is no god beside me; I kill and I make alive… and there is none that can deliver out of my hand” (32:39).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The song is a retelling of Israel’s story in miniature. God is the Rock, perfect and faithful. He found Israel in the wilderness, protected them like the apple of his eye, and carried them like an eagle carries its young. They grew fat in the land and forsook him. It is the same pattern you have seen throughout the wilderness story: grace, prosperity, rebellion, judgment.

The image of the eagle is beautiful. An eagle stirs up its nest so the young must fly, and then hovers beneath them, ready to catch them. It is a picture of God’s care that is both challenging and protective. He pushes his people out of comfort, and he does not let them fall.

The word “Rock” appears repeatedly. It is a name for God that stresses his stability and strength. Everything else in the song shifts, but the Rock does not. The nations’ gods are not rocks: “Their rock is not like our Rock” (32:31). In a world of change and disappointment, there is a foundation.

The accusation is heavy. Israel is called “a crooked and twisted generation” (32:5). The children have turned away from their father. This is a covenant lawsuit, with heaven and earth as the jury. But the sentence is not final. Verse 36 says, “The LORD will vindicate his people and have compassion on his servants.” The song moves from judgment to compassion. God’s last word is not wrath.

The final verses of the chapter return to Moses himself. He is told to go up Mount Nebo, look at the land, and die. He will not enter, “because you broke faith with me.” His own failure at Meribah has consequences. But the great leader receives a view of the land and a peaceful death, a last gift.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes the song in Romans 10:19 and 12:19, and 15:10, and in 1 Corinthians 10:22. Jesus compared himself to a hen gathering her chicks, and in the parable of the wicked tenants he spoke of the vineyard owner’s son, echoing Israel’s rejection. Revelation 15:3 says that the

redeemed sing “the song of Moses, the servant of God, and the song of the Lamb.” The Rock is Christ (1 Corinthians 10:4), and the foundation on which we build (Matthew 7:24-25).

STEP 6

Application

Read the song aloud once through. Notice which phrase speaks to you.

Ask whether you have grown “fat and kicked” in a season of ease. Return to the Rock.

Thank God for the image of the eagle, and for the ways he has both pushed and caught you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God as the Rock whose work is perfect.
- Confess where you have forgotten the Rock of your salvation.
- Ask him to vindicate his people and have compassion on them.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 28

“The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever, that we may do all the words of this law.”

DEUTERONOMY 29:29

DAY 195 · WEEK 28

Deuteronomy 33:1-34:12

Moses' final blessing; his death, the prophet yet to come

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 41 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 33:1-34:12. This is the end of the Pentateuch. Moses blesses the tribes and then climbs Mount Nebo to die. Read the last chapter slowly, and notice the final description of Moses.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the last day in the five books of Moses. Before he dies, Moses speaks a blessing over each of the tribes, much as Jacob did at the end of Genesis. Then the narrator describes his death on Mount Nebo, his burial, and a verdict on his life. The close of the book sets up the transition to Joshua and the conquest, but also leaves a hopeful question hanging: where is the prophet like Moses who is yet to come?

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD came from Sinai and dawned from Seir upon us; he shone forth from Mount Paran" (33:2).
2. "Yes, he loved his people… and they followed in your steps, receiving direction from you" (33:3).
3. Moses blesses the tribes, including Judah: "Hear, O LORD, the voice of Judah" (33:7), and Levi, who is to teach Jacob God's rules and offer incense (33:8-11).
4. "The eternal God is your dwelling place, and underneath are the everlasting arms" (33:27).
5. "Happy are you, O Israel! Who is like you, a people saved by the LORD, the shield of your help, and the sword of your triumph?" (33:29).

6. Moses goes up from the plains of Moab to Mount Nebo, and the LORD shows him all the land (34:1-4).
7. "So Moses the servant of the LORD died there in the land of Moab, according to the word of the LORD" (34:5).
8. "And there has not arisen a prophet since in Israel like Moses, whom the LORD knew face to face" (34:10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The blessing of the tribes shows Moses as a father and a pastor to the end. His last words are not rebuke but blessing. After forty years of leading a difficult people, his final act is to bless them, one tribe after another. A good leader leaves the people with a benediction.

The most famous verse is 33:27: "The eternal God is your dwelling place, and underneath are the everlasting arms." It is a fitting summary of Moses' message. God is the home of his people, as Psalm 90 said at the start of this unit. And underneath are the everlasting arms, a picture of unseen support. When we fall, we fall into the hands of God.

The death of Moses is told with beautiful restraint. He climbs the mountain, sees the land, and dies "according to the word of the LORD." The Hebrew can also mean "by the mouth of the LORD," and the rabbis said he died by a kiss. He is buried by God himself, and "no one knows the place of his burial to this day." There is no tomb to venerate. He was not worshiped, and God made sure that no one would turn his grave into a shrine.

The last paragraph is the verdict. Moses was 120 years old, with unimpaired eyesight and vigor. The people wept for thirty days. And then comes the line that looks forward: "There has not arisen a prophet since in Israel like Moses, whom the LORD knew face to face." It is a statement of Moses' greatness, and it also leaves a longing. God had promised another prophet like Moses (18:15). The Pentateuch ends by saying that he has not yet come.

This is why the end of Deuteronomy is not an ending. It is a pause in a larger story. The Law has done its work. It has described the covenant, shown Israel's need, and pointed forward. The rest of the Bible waits for someone greater than Moses.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 3:5-6 says that Moses was faithful "as a servant in all God's house," but Christ is faithful "as a son over God's house." Jude 9 mentions a dispute about the body of Moses. At the transfiguration, Moses appears with Jesus and talks with him about his departure (Luke

9:30-31). John 1:17 says, “The law was given through Moses; grace and truth came through Jesus Christ.” The everlasting arms are now the arms of Christ, who took the children in his arms and blessed them (Mark 10:16).

STEP 6

Application

Spend time with the verse “The eternal God is your dwelling place, and underneath are the everlasting arms.” Where do you need to feel them?

Think about how you want to finish your own life of service. Is there a blessing you want to leave?

Thank God for Moses, and for the one who is greater than Moses.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that underneath you are his everlasting arms.
- Thank him for Jesus, the greater prophet.
- Ask him to teach you to finish well and leave a legacy of faith.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 28

“The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever, that we may do all the words of this law.”

DEUTERONOMY 29:29

DAY 196 · WEEK 28

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Deuteronomy 29:29 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever, that we may do all the words of this law."

DEUTERONOMY 29:29

REST

Meditation

Deuteronomy 29:29 is a verse about the limits of knowledge and the shape of obedience. It comes at the end of a chapter of warning, and it sets out a balance that every believer needs.

"The secret things belong to the LORD our God." There are things we do not know and cannot know. Why a particular event happened, how God's sovereignty and human responsibility work together, what is hidden in the future. These belong to God. This is not a rebuke. It is a relief. We are not required to carry the weight of knowing everything.

"But the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever." God has spoken. He has made known his character, his promises, and his commands. These are not for specialists alone, but for us and our children. The word "forever" means that the revealed things are a permanent possession. Scripture is a gift to every generation.

“That we may do all the words of this law.” The purpose of revelation is obedience. God does not give us his word only to satisfy curiosity. He gives it so that we may live by it. The practical question is never “What does God know?” but “What has God told me to do?”

For the Christian, the verse is an invitation to humility and to action. Some questions will not be answered in this life. But the gospel has been revealed in Christ, and what we need for life and godliness has been given (2 Peter 1:3). Stop worrying about the secret things. Do what is revealed.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the book of Deuteronomy. You read the long section of laws about justice, warfare, and daily life, and the ritual of the firstfruits with its creed. You read the covenant ceremony at Ebal and Gerizim, and the detailed curses of disobedience. You read Moses’ call to choose life and the promise that God would circumcise the heart. In the Psalms, you prayed through the first sections of Psalm 119, which praises the word of God as a source of purity and comfort. You read the Song of Moses, with its image of God as the Rock and the eagle, and then Moses’ last blessing and his death on Mount Nebo. The week taught that God’s word is near, that the heart needs his help to love it, and that even in judgment, he leaves a way back.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Moses said, “The word is very near you, in your mouth and in your heart.” What practical difference does it make to you that God’s word is near, and not far off?

The book of Deuteronomy ends with the statement that no prophet had arisen like Moses. How does the New Testament answer that longing, and why does it matter?

Psalm 119 is a long prayer of love for God’s word. How would you describe your own feelings about Scripture, and what would help you to love it more?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give God the things you do not understand and ask him for trust.

Tell him what you want to obey that he has shown you.

Rest in him today.

DAY 197 · WEEK 29

Psalm 119:97-144

The commandments as wisdom, sweeter than honey

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Psalm · 48 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 119:97-144. Today's section includes one of the most famous verses in the psalm, verse 105. Read it as a prayer from someone who loves God's word and finds it a guide in the dark.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The third section of Psalm 119 begins with a cry of love: "Oh how I love your law!" It speaks of wisdom, guidance, and zeal. The psalmist is surrounded by wicked people who do not keep God's word, and he is grieved by their disobedience. Yet he finds in Scripture light, wisdom, and sweetness, and he holds to it with passion.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh how I love your law! It is my meditation all the day" (v. 97).
2. "Your commandment makes me wiser than my enemies, for it is ever with me" (v. 98).
3. "I have more understanding than all my teachers, for your testimonies are my meditation" (v. 99).
4. "How sweet are your words to my taste, sweeter than honey to my mouth!" (v. 103).
5. "Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path" (v. 105).
6. "I have sworn an oath and confirmed it, to keep your righteous rules" (v. 106).
7. "The unfolding of your words gives light; it imparts understanding to the simple" (v. 130).
8. "My eyes shed streams of tears, because people do not keep your law" (v. 136).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This section opens with an outpouring of love. The psalmist says it is his meditation all day long. It is not a duty that he squeezes in. It is the way he thinks. And the result is wisdom. He is wiser than his enemies, has more insight than his teachers, and understands more than the elders. These are not boasts about his intellect. He attributes it all to the word. The person who meditates on Scripture gains a wisdom that cleverness cannot give.

Verse 103 is one of the best descriptions of what it is to love the word: "How sweet are your words to my taste, sweeter than honey to my mouth." It is a picture of delight. God's word is not bitter medicine. It is food that we enjoy. In Ezekiel 3:3, the prophet eats a scroll and says it is as sweet as honey. In Revelation 10:9-10, John eats a scroll that is sweet in the mouth and bitter in the stomach. The word is sweet, but it can also be bitter, because it brings both joy and conviction.

Verse 105 is the best known: "Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path." It is a modest image. A lamp in the ancient world did not light a whole road. It showed the next few steps. This is how God usually guides us. We do not get a floodlight on the whole future. We get enough to take the next step. The word is for walking, not just for knowing.

Verse 130 says that the unfolding of God's words gives light to the simple. The word is not only for the educated. The humble and the simple can understand what is essential. God is not hiding his truth from them.

The last verses show the other side: the psalmist weeps because others do not keep the law. Love for God's word includes grief for those who reject it. A heart that is in tune with God will be broken by what breaks his.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the light of the world (John 8:12), and he said, "Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness." John says that the Word is the light that shines in the darkness (John 1:1-5). Paul says that the word of Christ should dwell in you richly (Colossians 3:16). Peter calls us to long for "the pure spiritual milk" of the word, "that by it you may grow up into salvation" (1 Peter 2:2). Jesus wept over Jerusalem (Luke 19:41).

STEP 6

Application

Memorize verse 105. Say it before you go out this week.

Ask what the "next step" is that the lamp is showing you now.

Let your heart be moved for those who do not know God's word. Pray for someone by name.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you love about his word, and what you find hard about it.
- Ask him for understanding as you meditate on it today.
- Ask him to give you a heart for those who do not know him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 29

"Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Do not be frightened, and do not be dismayed, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go."

JOSHUA 1:9

DAY 198 · WEEK 29

Psalm 119:145-176

With my whole heart I cry; your word is my hope

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Psalm · 32 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 119:145-176. This is the last section of the longest psalm. It is a series of cries for help, and it ends in a surprising way. Read the last verse carefully.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The final section of Psalm 119 is full of urgent prayer. The psalmist rises before dawn to cry out, and he prays at night. He is pursued by those who are far from God's law, and yet he finds that God is near. The psalm ends not with a triumphant note, but with a confession that he has gone astray like a lost sheep, and a plea for the shepherd to seek him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "With my whole heart I cry; answer me, O LORD! I will keep your statutes" (v. 145).
2. "I rose before dawn and cried for help; I hoped in your words" (v. 147).
3. "You are near, O LORD, and all your commandments are true" (v. 151).
4. "The sum of your word is truth, and every one of your righteous rules endures forever" (v. 160).
5. "Great peace have those who love your law; nothing can make them stumble" (v. 165).
6. "I rejoice at your word like one who finds great spoil" (v. 162).
7. "Let my cry come before you, O LORD; give me understanding according to your word!" (v. 169).
8. "I have gone astray like a lost sheep; seek your servant, for I do not forget your commandments" (v. 176).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The closing section is a prayer of desperate faith. “With my whole heart I cry.” The psalmist prays early in the morning and late at night. He is not casual about prayer. He is urgent, and he bases his urgency on God’s word: “I hoped in your words.” The word is the ground of his hope. He prays what God has promised, and he trusts that God will do it.

Verse 151 is a short statement of great comfort: “You are near, O LORD.” Surrounded by those who persecute him, the psalmist holds on to the fact that God is near. He does not say that his circumstances have changed. He says that God is close, and that is enough.

Verse 160 is a profound statement about Scripture: “The sum of your word is truth.” The whole of it, taken together, is truth. Each part is true, and the whole is more than the parts. It is a good verse to remember as you read the Bible as a whole. Each passage is a piece of a single truth.

The great promise of verse 165 is peace: “Great peace have those who love your law; nothing can make them stumble.” This is not the peace of having no problems. It is the peace of those whose lives are rooted in God’s word. Though they may be shaken, they are not toppled.

Then the final verse. After 175 verses about loving, keeping, and delighting in God’s law, the psalmist ends with, “I have gone astray like a lost sheep; seek your servant.” It is a moving confession. The most devoted lover of the word still needs a shepherd. He cannot keep the law perfectly. He needs God to find him. And he says, “I do not forget your commandments.” Even a lost sheep remembers the shepherd’s voice.

This is where the law leads: not to self-righteousness, but to a cry for a shepherd.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus told the parable of the lost sheep, in which the shepherd leaves the ninety-nine to seek the one (Luke 15:3-7), and he said, “I am the good shepherd” (John 10:11). Isaiah 53:6 says, “All we like sheep have gone astray… and the LORD has laid on him the iniquity of us all.” Peter says, “You were straying like sheep, but have now returned to the Shepherd and Overseer of your souls” (1 Peter 2:25). The psalmist’s last prayer is answered in Christ.

STEP 6

Application

Pray verse 176 as your own. Admit where you have gone astray, and ask the shepherd to seek you.

Think about your morning and evening habits of prayer. Is there a small way to deepen them?

Spend time thanking God for the peace of those who love his law.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Cry out to God with your whole heart, telling him where you have gone astray.
- Thank Jesus, the good shepherd who found you.
- Ask him to keep his word near you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 29

"Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Do not be frightened, and do not be dismayed, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go."

JOSHUA 1:9

DAY 199 · WEEK 29

Review and Reflection

Unit 7 review, Wilderness, Numbers & Deuteronomy

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one. You shall love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your might."
>
> DEUTERONOMY 6:4-5

REST

Meditation

Deuteronomy 6:4-5 is the unit's anchor verse. It is the greatest commandment, and the center of the book that you have just finished reading. Read it aloud once more before you continue.

"Hear, O Israel." The word "hear" in Hebrew is shema, and it means to listen and obey. After forty years of failing to listen, Israel is told again to hear. This is the way that every part of the covenant begins. Faith comes by hearing.

"The LORD our God, the LORD is one." There is one God. There is no rival, no partner, and no competing power. He is the LORD, the covenant name given at the burning bush. And he is "our God," bound to his people in love. The oneness of God is the foundation of Israel's life, and of the Christian faith.

"You shall love the LORD your God." The commandment is to love. This is not a request for mere compliance. The whole law, the sacrifices, the festivals, the justice, is meant to be the expression of love for God. Moses told the people many times in this book that obedience should flow from love.

"With all your heart and with all your soul and with all your might." The love is to be total. Heart is the center of thought and will. Soul is the whole self, life itself. Might is strength, resources, energy. Nothing is held back. Jesus added "mind" when he quoted the verse (Mark 12:30), but the sense is the same: everything we are belongs to God.

For the Christian, the verse is both a command and a promise. We cannot keep it on our own. But God promised in Deuteronomy 30:6 that he would circumcise our hearts so that we would love him. In Christ, that promise is fulfilled. The Spirit pours God's love into our hearts (Romans 5:5), and we love because he first loved us (1 John 4:19).

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

In Unit 7 you have read the books of Numbers and Deuteronomy, the forty years in the wilderness and the sermons of Moses that prepared Israel for the land. You began with the census at Sinai and saw the camp arranged around the tabernacle, with the Levites set apart as substitutes for the firstborn. You read the blessing that God told Aaron to speak over his people, and Psalm 90, Moses' prayer about the brevity of life and the eternity of God.

You followed Israel as it left Sinai with the cloud above and the ark in front, and you saw the march break down in complaining. You read the story of the twelve spies and the decision of the people not to enter the land, and the sentence of forty years. You prayed Psalm 95 and heard its warning, "Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts." You read of Korah's rebellion, Aaron's budding staff, and the red heifer, and of Moses' sin at the rock and the bronze serpent that healed those who looked. You heard the oracles of Balaam and the promise of a star from Jacob.

You read of the second generation. They fell at Baal of Peor, were numbered again, and received Joshua as their leader. You read the offerings and the vows, the war against Midian, the stages of the journey, the boundaries of the land, and the cities of refuge, whose manslayers were freed by the death of the high priest.

Then Moses began to preach. He looked back at the journey and told the people that God had carried them as a man carries his son. He restated the Ten Commandments and gave the Shema, the greatest commandment. He told Israel that God's choice was not because of their righteousness, and he retold the golden calf. You paused to study the three offices of Christ as prophet, priest, and king. You read the law of the king and the promise of a prophet like Moses. You read the many laws of justice and mercy, the creed of the firstfruits, the covenant at Ebal and Gerizim, and the blessings and curses. Moses called Israel to choose life, taught them the Song of the Rock, blessed the tribes, and died on Mount Nebo. All along, you prayed through Psalm 78, which told the story as a lesson for children, and Psalm 119, which praised the word of God.

The unit taught that unbelief is the root of rebellion, that God is patient and faithful, that the heart must be changed by God, and that the whole of the law is to be summed up in love.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What does Israel's wilderness rebellion reveal about the human heart?

Look back at the spies (Numbers 13 and 14), Korah (Numbers 16), and Psalm 95. Consider what Moses says in Deuteronomy 29:4 about the heart. Ask what Israel needed that miracles could not give.

What is the structure of Deuteronomy, and why does it matter that it resembles a covenant treaty?

Recall the pattern: a historical review (chapters 1 to 4), the commandments (5 to 26), the blessings and curses (27 to 30), and the arrangements for the future (31 to 34). Think about why God would bind his people with a covenant instead of only commanding.

What does Moses mean by the blessings and curses in Deuteronomy 27 and 28?

Review Deuteronomy 28:1-14 and 28:15-68, and the reason in 28:47. Read Galatians 3:10-14, and consider how the curses were fulfilled in Israel's history and in Christ.

How does Moses function as a type of Christ, and where does he fall short?

Think about Moses as prophet, mediator, intercessor, and leader. Consider Numbers 20, Deuteronomy 18:15, and Deuteronomy 34:10. Read Hebrews 3:1-6 and ask what the Son does that the servant could not.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for carrying you through these years of wilderness and patience.

Thank him for Christ as prophet, priest, and king.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.